

Duke alumni investors: angel, seed and early stage

SimReal outreach list · built 2026-10-05 · public professional information only

71

verified investors

12

high fit (AI infra,
data, dev tools,
fintech, quant)

30 / 29

medium / low fit

8

published
personal emails

58

checked and left
out

- **Who qualifies:** a Duke degree (Trinity, Pratt, Fuqua, Law, Med or the Graduate School) finished in 2018 or earlier, plus a 2026 decision-making role (GP, managing or founding partner, MD, investing partner, solo GP, or active angel) at an investor that writes angel to Series A checks.
- **How it was checked:** each person was found by a web sweep, verified against public sources by one agent, and then challenged by a separate fact-checker. Most evidence comes from search-result snippets, because fund websites block direct access from this environment.
- **Contacts:** 8 people have a personal email that they or their fund published. Everyone else has the fund's official route (pitch inbox or form), LinkedIn or X. Emails were never guessed from a pattern or taken from data-broker sites. A warm intro through Duke (Duke Capital Partners, Duke I&E, DukeGEN) beats a cold email.
- **Hooks** are one-line openers built only from facts with a cited source. Check them before sending.

At a glance

#	Name	Firm	Title	Duke	Fit
1	Cassie Young	Primary Venture Partners	General Partner	Class of '05	● High
2	David Beisel	NextView Ventures	Co-founder & Partner	BA Economics '98	● High
3	Jake Flomenberg	Wing Venture Capital	Partner	BSE ECE, CS & Economics	● High
4	Logan Allin	Fin Capital	Founder & Managing Partner	BA Public Policy & Political Science '03	● High
5	Mark Kraynak	Acrew Capital	Founding Partner	BSE Electrical Engineering & English, Pratt '95	● High
6	Naveen Rao	Angel investor	Angel investor	BS EECS	● High
7	Steve Pagliuca	PagsGroup	Founder & CEO	BA '77	● High
8	Wes Barton	Third Prime	Co-founder & General Partner	JD, Duke Law '02	● High
9	Zach Perret	Mischief	Co-founder, Mischief	BS Physics and Chemistry	● High
10	Howie Liu	Angel investor	Angel investor	BS Mechanical Engineering and Public Policy '09	● High
11	Kevin King	53 Stations	Co-founder & General Partner	BS Economics & Mathematics '06	● High
12	Mark Peter Davis	Interplay	Managing Partner	BA Economics and History	● High
13	Danny Hadar	Jibe Ventures	Co-founder & Managing Partner	MBA, Fuqua '07	● Medium
14	Greg Baker	Alumni Ventures	Executive Partner	MBA, Fuqua '91	● Medium

15	Gregg Bordes	Front Porch Venture Partners	Co-founder & Managing Partner	MBA, Fuqua '12	● Medium
16	Howard Lerman	Angel investor	Angel investor	Bachelor's, History '02	● Medium
17	Joe Mancini	Front Porch Venture Partners	Co-founder & General Partner	MBA, Fuqua '12	● Medium
18	Katelyn Donnelly	Avalanche VC	Founder & Managing Partner	BA Economics & Political Science '08	● Medium
19	Marc Andrusko	Oak HC/FT	Partner	Undergraduate degree, magna cum laude	● Medium
20	Rob Go	NextView Ventures	Co-founder & Partner	BS Economics '01	● Medium
21	Thomas D. Lehrman	Teamworthy Ventures	Co-founder & Managing Partner	BA	● Medium
22	W. Bradford (Brad) Stephens	Blockchain Capital	Co-founder & Managing Partner	BA Economics '98	● Medium
23	Will Bumpus	Westbound Equity Partners	Partner	BA Psychology and Asian & Middle Eastern Studies '09	● Medium
24	Blake Byers	Byers Capital	Founder	BS Biomedical Engineering, Pratt · BS Economics	● Medium
25	David Cummings	Atlanta Ventures	Founder & CEO	BS Economics	● Medium
26	Deb Liu	Ember AI	Co-founder & angel investor	BSE Civil Engineering, Pratt '98	● Medium
27	Jason Fernandez	Creci Ventures	General Partner	MBA, Fuqua '08	● Medium
28	Jeremy Levine	Bessemer Venture Partners	Partner	BS Computer Science & Economics '95	● Medium
29	Kent Ho	S28 Capital	Founder & General Partner	BA Economics	● Medium
30	Lawson DeVries	Grotech Ventures	Managing General Partner	MBA, Fuqua	● Medium
31	Mengxi Lu	Angel investor	Angel investor	Master of Engineering Management '12	● Medium
32	Robert Ravanshenas	Maven Ventures	Investment Partner	BS Economics '15	● Medium
33	Scott Raney	Redpoint Ventures	Managing Director	BS Electrical Engineering, Pratt '91	● Medium
34	Sergey Khusnetdinov	Ga^3in Ventures	Founder & Managing Partner	MBA · 2013	● Medium
35	Shaan Puri	Shaan's All Access Fund	Founder & GP	BS Biology '10	● Medium
36	William Crowder	Aperture Venture Capital	Co-founder & Managing Partner	MBA, Fuqua '99	● Medium
37	Amit Mehra	Borderless Capital	General Partner	MBA, Fuqua	● Medium
38	Ashley Flucas	Flucas Ventures	Founder & General Partner	BA Political Science '08	● Medium

39	Jason Freedman	Peak State Ventures	General Partner	BA Public Policy & Economics '02	● Medium
40	Pamir Gelenbe	Libertus Capital	Founder & Managing Partner	BSc Electrical Engineering	● Medium
41	Padowithz "Pad" Alce	Angel investor, Duke Capital Partners	Angel investor	LLM Law & Entrepreneurship, Duke Law '11	● Medium
42	Lisa Burton O'Toole	HearstLab	Executive Director	BSE Mechanical Engineering, Pratt '07	● Medium
43	Adam Besvinick	Looking Glass Capital	Founder & Managing Partner	BA Public Policy Studies '09	● Low
44	Ali Behbahani	NEA	Partner & Co-Head of Healthcare	Bachelor's degrees in Biomedical Engineering, Electrical Engineering & Chemistry	● Low
45	Dan Levitan	Maveron	Co-founder & General Partner	BA '79	● Low
46	Doug Brown	Dental Innovation Alliance	Co-founder & Managing Partner	BS '78 · MBA, Fuqua '84	● Low
47	Gonzalo Costa	NXTP Ventures	Co-founder & General Partner	MBA, Fuqua '01	● Low
48	Jeff Terrell	Arboretum Ventures	Managing Partner	MBA, Fuqua '13	● Low
49	Jim Scheinman	Maven Ventures	Founding Managing Partner	BS Neuropsychology, Trinity '88	● Low
50	John Tough	Energize Capital	Co-founder & Managing Partner	BS	● Low
51	Kathryn Minshew	XFactor Ventures	Operating Partner & Angel investor	BA Political Science & French '08	● Low
52	Kerry Rupp	True Wealth Ventures	General Partner	BA Biology '93	● Low
53	Lindy Morris Fishburne	Breakout Ventures	Founding Managing Partner	BA Cultural & Physical Anthropology '92	● Low
54	Lisa Blau	Able Partners	Founding Partner	BA '97	● Low
55	Namita Thapar	Angel investor	Shark Tank India investor	MBA, Fuqua '01	● Low
56	Paul Straub	Wireframe Ventures	Co-founder & Managing Partner	MBA, Fuqua '05	● Low
57	Sydney Thomas	Symphonic Capital	Founder & General Partner	BA Public Policy '10	● Low
58	Todd Pietri	Activate Venture Partners	Co-founder & Co-Managing Partner	BA English	● Low
59	Carmichael Roberts	Material Impact	Co-founder & Managing Partner	BS Organic Chemistry '90 · PhD Organic Chemistry '95	● Low
60	David Lamond	Lamond Ventures	Managing Partner	BA History, Trinity '97 · JD, Duke Law '06	● Low
61	John Glushik	HG Ventures	Managing Director	BS Mechanical Engineering & Materials Science, Pratt '90	● Low
62	Josh Felser	Climactic	Co-founder & Managing Partner	BA Political Science & Economics '86 · MBA, Fuqua '90	● Low
63	Lia Cromwell	UpWest	Partner	BA Public Policy, Economics & Spanish '15	● Low
64	Lori Cashman	Visible Ventures	Founder & General Partner	BA '94	● Low

65	Luis von Ahn	Angel investor	Angel investor	BS Mathematics '00	● Low
66	Nikin Shah	Front Porch Venture Partners	Co-founder & General Partner	MBA, Fuqua '12	● Low
67	Salman Azhar	Azimuth Opportunity Fund	General Partner	MS Computer Science '90 · PhD Computer Science '94	● Low
68	Squire Servance	Syridex Bio	Founder & Managing Partner	JD, Duke Law '08 · MBA, Fuqua '08	● Low
69	Camille Samuels	Venrock	Partner	Bachelor's, Biology '93	● Low
70	Jared Weinstein	Overton	Founder	BA Public Policy '02	● Low
71	Melinda French Gates	Pivotal Ventures	Founder	BS Computer Science & Economics '86 · MBA, Fuqua '87	● Low

High fit · 12

1 **Cassie Young**

High fit

General Partner · **Primary Venture Partners**

Duke: Class of '05 | Confidence: High | New York, NY

Cassie Young is a General Partner at Primary Venture Partners in New York, where she specializes in enterprise AI and leads the operating team; Primary's \$625M Fund V is all seed. She previously spent about 15 years in go-to-market roles, most recently as Chief Customer Officer of CM Group.

Stage	Seed and pre-seed; Primary's \$625M Fund V (final close Feb 2026) is all seed, with \$5-10M average checks across 40-50 companies
Relevant deals	Lyric (Primary led the seed, Jan 2025, and joined the Series B, Aug 2025); 1mind AI Superhumans (Series A, 2024); Lantern (customer-data/AI signals, Series A, 2022); Alium (AI buyer insights, Seed, 2020)
Why them	She leads seed rounds at a seed-only fund with fresh capital, and her page says she is looking for founders in fintech and enterprise AI. Her deals so far are mostly app-layer enterprise AI and GTM tools rather than model-training infrastructure.
Hook	<i>Your Primary page says you're looking for founders in fintech and enterprise AI; we built Xitadel, a trading RL environment that lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: founders@primary.vc (Primary's founder inbox); fintech@primary.vc for fintech

2 David Beisel

High fit

Co-founder & Partner · **NextView Ventures**

Duke: BA Economics '98 | Confidence: High | Boston, MA (Boston Globe Tech Power Players; NextView has NYC, Boston and SF offices)

David Beisel is Co-founder and Partner at NextView Ventures, a seed firm with a generalist 'Everyday Economy' thesis that leads about 10-12 seed investments a year. In 2026 he wrote NextView's investment posts on Tero and Walden Robotics, and the firm backed continual-RL platform Skyfall AI. He also holds a Stanford MBA.

Stage	Seed; NextView leads about 10-12 seed investments a year
Relevant deals	Skyfall AI: NextView seed investment (Seed VC-II round, July 20, 2026, alongside Fidelity, Garage Capital, Inovia, M13 and Touring Capital). Skyfall's first product, Morpheus, is a continual reinforcement learning platform for AI researchers that lets agents learn inside persistent, non-stationary environments. This is a firm-level deal; that Beisel personally led it is not verified. Tero (Jan 2026) and Walden Robotics (Jul 2026) appear on his NextView author page; their sectors were not verified.
Why them	He is an active seed lead. In 2026 NextView backed Skyfall AI, a continual-RL environment platform for AI researchers that sits next to SimReal's RL environments and verifiers. The firm's main thesis is generalist 'Everyday Economy', not AI infra.
Hook	<i>You co-founded NextView, which backed Skyfall AI's continual-RL platform in a July seed round; we build RL environments and verifiers for LLM post-training, right next door.</i>
Contact	Email: david@nextviewventures.com (published at www.davidbeisel.com (search snippet, search limited to davidbeisel.com; also davidbeisel.com/#bio)) Fund route: Warm referral preferred (NextView's stated approach): nextview.vc/approach Site: davidbeisel.com ; blog genuinevc.com/about-me

3 Jake Flomenberg

High fit

Partner · **Wing Venture Capital**

Duke: BSE ECE, CS & Economics | Confidence: High

Jake Flomenberg is a Partner at Wing Venture Capital, investing from seed to Series B in AI infrastructure, foundation models, AI applications and security. In 2026 he co-led Gray Swan AI's \$40M Series A; earlier he was at Accel and held product and engineering roles at Splunk and Cloudera.

Stage	Seed to Series B: AI/ML, AI infrastructure and foundation models, next-generation infrastructure, SaaS, security
Relevant deals	Gray Swan AI (AI security), \$40M Series A, 2026, co-led by Wing (Jake) and Madrona; SiMa.ai (edge ML), board member, Series B (\$37M, 2022); aggregator-reported and not independently verified: Moonshine AI seed (2025), Pixee seed (\$15M, 2025). Earlier at Accel: Demisto, Sumo Logic.
Why them	An active seed/Series A lead in AI infrastructure and AI security. In 2026 he co-led Gray Swan AI's Series A, a company that evaluates and red-teams model behavior, which is close to SimReal's work on RL environments and verifiers.
Hook	<i>You co-led the \$40M Series A in Gray Swan AI, which red-teams and evaluates model behavior; we build RL environments and verifiers that improve that behavior, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/jacobflomenberg Site: medium.com/@JakeFlomenberg

4 Logan Allin

High fit

Founder & Managing Partner · **Fin Capital**

Duke: BA Public Policy & Political Science '03 | Confidence: High | San Francisco, CA

Logan Allin is Founder and Managing Partner of Fin Capital, a B2B fintech investor he started in 2018 that backs companies from pre-seed to pre-IPO, with enterprise AI and wealth/capital markets among its focus areas. The firm passed \$1B in AUM in about three years. He was previously a VP at SoFi Ventures.

Stage	Pre-seed to pre-IPO B2B fintech. Personal investing profile lists pre-seed, seed and Series A. Focus areas include Enterprise AI, BankTech, B2B Payments, CFO Tech Stack, Wealth/Capital Markets and RiskTech/Cyber.
Relevant deals	Primitive, an AI agent operating system for financial services, backed by Fin Capital and Pelion (round and year not stated). WitnessAI, an AI security company that raised \$58M in Jan 2026, was featured at Fin Capital's demo day on scaling AI (Fin Capital's role in that round not confirmed). Strategic partnership with Blend360 on AI-powered enterprise innovation. Fin Capital also made a new investment on 14 Jan 2026.
Why them	Founder and Managing Partner of a B2B fintech fund that invests from pre-seed. Fin Capital names Enterprise AI and Wealth/Capital Markets as core sub-sectors and backs AI-for-finance companies like Primitive. He has active Duke ties through the FinTech advisory board.
Hook	<i>You back Primitive's AI agent OS for financial services and target Enterprise AI and capital markets; we built Xitadel, an RL environment that lifted an open model's trading 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch form: fin.capital/contact LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/loganallin

5 Mark Kraynak

High fit

Founding Partner · **Acrew Capital**

Duke: BSE Electrical Engineering & English, Pratt '95 | Confidence: High

Mark Kraynak is a Founding Partner at Acrew Capital, which he co-founded in 2019, investing in cybersecurity, data, enterprise tech and fintech from seed through Series B. He spent nearly 13 years at Imperva, latterly as SVP and GM of its enterprise business. In March 2026 Acrew led Reclaim Security's \$20M Series A.

Stage	Seed, Series A and Series B. His checks run \$1M-\$7M (sweet spot about \$4M); Acrew's fund is \$250M
Relevant deals	Reclaim Security (Acrew led its \$20M Series A in March 2026, \$26M raised in total; Kraynak quoted as Founding Partner). Acrew also backed Nextdata (seed) and Nokod Security (seed, 2023); his personal role in those two is unverified.
Why them	Founding Partner who leads seed and Series A rounds in data, security, enterprise infrastructure and fintech. He led a Series A in 2026
Hook	<i>You spoke for Acrew when it led Reclaim Security's \$20M Series A in March, and you invest across security and data; we build the verifiers and expert data that make AI agents reliable.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Warm intro; firm site acrewcapital.com (no pitch inbox verified) X: x.com/raknak Site: mark-kraynak.medium.com and Forbes contributor page www.forbes.com/sites/markkraynak (search snippets)
Note	Fund already in SimReal pipeline: acrew-capital (contact: Asad Khaliq)

6 Naveen Rao

High fit

Angel investor · **Angel investor**

Duke: BS EECS | Confidence: High | unclear (US)

Angel investor in AI chips, edge AI and LLM infrastructure at pre-seed and seed, and co-founder and CEO of Unconventional AI, which raised a \$475M seed in December 2025. He previously co-founded Nervana Systems, acquired by Intel, and MosaicML, acquired by Databricks for \$1.3B. His angel checks include Cleanlab and Topos Bio.

Stage Pre-seed and seed (per angel profile)

Relevant deals Topos Bio (AI foundation model for drug discovery): angel in the \$10.5M seed led by Boldstart, Threshold and Neo, Jan 2026. Cleanlab (ML data-quality tooling): angel in the \$5M seed led by Bain Capital Ventures (c. 2022). Also put \$10M of his own money into his own company Unconventional AI's \$475M seed (Dec 2025).

Why them Built MosaicML (LLM training infrastructure) and angel-invests in AI chips, edge AI and LLM infrastructure at pre-seed and seed, with a January 2026 deal on record. This is a close match for RL environments and verifiers for post-training.

Hook *You co-founded MosaicML and backed Cleanlab's seed; we build RL environments, verifiers and expert data for LLM post-training, including a trading environment that lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.*

Contact Email: not found (not published)

7 Steve Pagliuca

High fit

Founder & CEO · **PagsGroup**

Duke: BA '77 | Confidence: High | Weston, Massachusetts (PagsGroup base) per https://tracxn.com/d/private-equity/pagsgroup/_4WXVbiOfqaG6sbweiXM46vDnWljylinXQ_AVwHHil8Q (search snippet)

Steve Pagliuca is founder and CEO of PagsGroup, his single-LP family investment firm, and a senior advisor to Bain Capital, where he was previously co-chairman. PagsGroup co-led Liquid AI's seed round in December 2023 and Memcyco's \$37M Series A in January 2026. He sits on Duke's Board of Trustees.

Stage Family office investing his own capital. It co-led Liquid AI's seed (Dec 2023) and Memcyco's \$37M Series A (Jan 2026), and also does Series C and growth deals. The firm calls itself a growth capital investor with a portfolio spread across VC, PE, real assets and public markets, so checks are large.

Relevant deals Liquid AI: seed (~\$37.5M), co-led by PagsGroup with OSS Capital, Dec 2023 (MIT spinoff building new AI foundation models). Memcyco: \$37M Series A, Jan 2026, led by NAventures, E. Leon Jimenes and PagsGroup with Capri Ventures and Venture Guides joining (real-time digital-risk / account-takeover fraud protection; \$47M raised in total). True Footage Series C (Apr 2026) and Gameto Series C (Aug 2025), both from a portfolio listing snippet.

Why them Invests his own money and co-led the seed of an AI foundation-model company (Liquid AI) and a 2026 fintech Series A (Memcyco). In 2026 he publicly named AI a key long-term investment focus. One caveat: his checks are large and growth-leaning, so a small seed round may sit below his usual size.

Hook *You co-led Liquid AI's seed through PagsGroup and named AI a key investment focus in July 2026; we build RL environments and verifiers for post-training foundation models.*

Contact Email: not found (not published)
Fund route: 'Get in Touch' section on the official site www.pagsgroup.com (no published inbox)

8 Wes Barton

High fit

Co-founder & General Partner · **Third Prime**

Duke: JD, Duke Law '02 | Confidence: High | Nashville, TN

Co-founder and General Partner of Third Prime, a Nashville seed fund that backs fintech and proptech companies. The fund co-led the \$18.5M seed of Limited, which offers enterprise banking across crypto and fiat. He previously spent a decade at Trimaran and Trian, after roles at Bank of America and Skadden.

Stage	Seed; often leads or co-leads; check sizes reported variously (\$250K-\$3M per VC Sheet, \$1M-\$5M per another profile)
Relevant deals	Limited (enterprise banking across crypto and fiat): Third Prime co-led \$18.5M seed with North Island Ventures, The House Fund and Collab+Currency; extended seed reported Sep 2026. Third Prime made 9 new investments in the prior 12 months (2025 profile).
Why them	Decision-making GP at a seed fund focused on fintech that led/co-led a crypto-and-fiat banking seed round in 2026.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Third Prime, which co-led Limited's \$18.5M seed in crypto-and-fiat banking; we built Xitadel, a trading RL environment that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/wes-barton-35a8455

9 Zach Perret

High fit

Co-founder, Mischief · **Mischief**

Duke: BS Physics and Chemistry | Confidence: High | San Francisco (Mischief and Plaid base)

Co-founder and CEO of Plaid and co-founder, with Lauren Farleigh, of Mischief, a San Francisco seed fund that writes \$1-3M initial checks into founder-driven software startups. Mischief led Hamming.ai's \$3.8M seed in AI voice-agent testing, and he angel-invested in Lassie's Series A in June 2026.

Stage	Seed via Mischief (\$1-3M initial checks, often leads); personal angel checks from seed to Series B
Relevant deals	Personal angel: Lassie (Series A, \$35M led by a16z, Jun 2026); Comulate (Series B, Feb 2025); Fragment (seed, Jul 2024). Mischief (co-founded fund): led Hamming.ai's \$3.8M seed (AI voice-agent testing, Dec 2024); Polar \$9.86M seed and DataLane (2025, led by Farleigh).
Why them	Fintech-infrastructure founder who runs a pre-seed/seed software fund and is still investing in 2026; a trading-model environment sits squarely in his fintech domain.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Plaid and Mischief, which led Hamming.ai's seed in AI voice-agent testing; we build verifiers and RL environments for finance, where Xitadel lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Site: zachperret.com

10 Howie Liu

High fit

Angel investor · **Angel investor**

Duke: BS Mechanical Engineering and Public Policy '09 | Confidence: Medium

Angel investor in AI infrastructure and applications, and co-founder and CEO of Airtable, which serves more than 500,000 organizations and launched Superagent, its first standalone product in 13 years, in January 2026. His angel checks include Fireworks AI, Decagon and Galileo AI in 2024 and Sundial's Series A in July 2025.

Stage Angel, seed to Series B

Relevant deals Sundial (AI analytics; angel in \$16M Series A / \$23M total led by DJ Patil, Jul 2025); Fireworks AI (Series A Mar 2024 and Series B Jul 2024); Decagon (angel in Series A, Jun 2024); Galileo AI (seed, Feb 2024)

Why them Personal angel checks into AI infrastructure (Fireworks AI) and AI agents/apps, with a verified deal in July 2025; his own company is now shipping AI agents.

Hook *You angel-invested in Fireworks AI and Decagon in 2024 and Sundial in 2025; we build the RL environments and verifiers that post-train LLMs for expert work, starting with trading.*

Contact Email: not found (not published)

11 Kevin King

High fit

Co-founder & General Partner · **53 Stations**

Duke: BS Economics & Mathematics '06 | Confidence: Medium | Boston area (search snippet); 53 Stations is Chicago-based

Kevin King is Co-founder and General Partner of 53 Stations, the \$190M early-stage fund backed by The Pritzker Organization, which invests from seed to Series B across fintech, wealth tech and AI. He was previously a Partner at General Catalyst and earlier worked at Goldman Sachs and Windhorse Capital Management.

Stage Seed to Series B; 53 Stations leads and co-invests from a \$190M Fund I backed by The Pritzker Organization. It led Kaya's \$5.3M seed (Jan 2025, with RXR). Its 2026 deals seen are Series B (Wealth.com, Flex).

Relevant deals Range (AI-powered wealth management; joined the \$60M Series C, Dec 2025); Wealth.com (Series B, Apr 2026); Flex (Series B-II, Jul 2026); Kaya (led \$5.3M seed, Jan 2025). No verified seed AI-infra deals.

Why them 53 Stations writes seed-to-Series B checks (it led Kaya's seed in Jan 2025) and lists fintech and AI among its focus areas. King's Duke math/econ degree and his Goldman Sachs and Windhorse Capital background suit a quant-built trading RL environment. The firm's 2026 deals seen so far are Series B fintech/wealth-tech, and no seed AI-infra deal is verified.

Hook *You worked at Goldman Sachs and Windhorse Capital, and your fund backed AI-powered wealth manager Range; we built Xitadel, an RL environment that lifted an open model's trading 12% on unseen market data.*

Contact Email: not found (not published)
Fund route: info@53stations.com (general inquiries) or contact form
www.53stations.com/contact

12 Mark Peter Davis

High fit

Managing Partner · **Interplay**

Duke: BA Economics and History | Confidence: Medium

Mark Peter Davis is Managing Partner of Interplay, a New York firm founded in 2012 that runs a seed and Series A fund, an accelerator and a startup studio. Interplay backs SaaS, fintech and AI companies, including fintech-infrastructure company Knot at Series A in 2023. He founded the Duke Venture Community.

Stage	Pre-seed, seed and Series A. The venture fund usually enters at seed or Series A. There is also an accelerator and a startup studio.
Relevant deals	Knot (fintech infrastructure, Series A, Aug 2023, \$10M); Provi (Series A, Apr 2020, \$20M). The discovery record also says he was an early investor in Coinbase, which I did not verify.
Why them	Seed and Series A fund with a stated focus on SaaS, fintech and AI, including a fintech-infrastructure Series A (Knot). He founded the Duke Venture Community, which gives a strong Duke-alumni angle.
Hook	<i>You backed fintech-infrastructure company Knot at Series A in 2023; we've built Xitadel, an RL trading environment that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Engage page www.interplay.vc/engage ; virtual two-minute pitch sessions: www.interplay.vc/isthisathing LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/markpeterdavis Site: mpd.medium.com (Medium blog, search snippet); podcast 'Innovation with Mark Peter Davis' (podcasts.apple.com/us/podcast/innovation-with-mark-peter-davis/id15481)

Medium fit · 30

13 Danny Hadar

Medium fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Jibe Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '07 | Confidence: High | Tel Aviv, Israel

Co-founder and Managing Partner of Jibe Ventures, which he started with Assaf Jacobi in 2020 to back Israeli founders at pre-seed and seed. In 2025 Jibe led Fabrix Security's \$8M seed. Earlier he was a venture partner at Peregrine Ventures and an angel with 20+ seed investments, including Snyk.

Stage	Pre-seed, seed, seed+; earlier personal angel checks \$25K-\$200K
Relevant deals	Jibe: led Fabrix Security \$8M seed (Sep 2025); led Modulight Biotherapeutics \$12.2M seed with LocalGlobe (Nov 2025); ZyG \$58M seed (Mar 2026); Notch.cx \$30M Series A (Mar 2026). Personal angel (earlier years): Snyk, Bonobo (acq. Salesforce), Geoforce (acq. LLR).
Why them	Decision-making MP at an active pre-seed/seed fund investing in AI and cyber, but the fund backs Israeli founders, which SimReal is not.
Hook	<i>You were a seed angel in Snyk and co-founded Jibe, which led Fabrix Security's \$8M seed; we build verifiers and RL environments for LLM post-training, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/dannyhadar X: x.com/dannyhadar

14 Greg Baker

Medium fit

Executive Partner · **Alumni Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '91 | Confidence: High

Greg Baker is an Executive Partner at Alumni Ventures and runs Towerview Ventures, AV's fund that co-invests in Duke-connected companies alongside lead VCs. A partner at AV since 2017, he founded Bascom Ventures, AV's Wisconsin fund, and has helped lead 100+ investments. He calls himself a generalist with a passion for infrastructure, especially energy.

Stage	Invests from seed to growth. Towerview runs deal-by-deal syndicates and diversified funds that co-invest in Duke-connected companies alongside lead VCs, so it is a co-investor, not a lead.
Relevant deals	none found (no specific AI, data or fintech deals surfaced; 100+ investments across sectors)
Why them	Generalist early-stage co-investor whose Duke-connection mandate matches SimReal through its Duke COO. He states an interest in infrastructure, but it leans toward energy. AV joins rounds led by other VCs, so SimReal would need a lead investor first.
Hook	<i>You've helped lead 100+ investments at Alumni Ventures with a stated passion for infrastructure; we build RL environments and verifiers, the training infrastructure behind LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch form: www.av.vc/entrepreneurs (AV invests only once a round has a lead VC); Towerview page www.av.vc/funds/towerview LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/gregebaker Site: www.av.vc/people/greg-baker (official AV bio, search snippet); techoptimist.vc/people/greg-baker (AV podcast page, search snippet)

15 Gregg Bordes

Medium fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Front Porch Venture Partners**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '12 | Confidence: High | Research Triangle (Cary/Raleigh), North Carolina

Gregg Bordes is co-founder and Managing Partner of Front Porch Venture Partners, a Triangle-based firm that invests in Southeast VC funds and directly in early-stage startups across enterprise software, fintech and healthcare services. Its Fund II closed at \$20M in 2024. He has 20+ years in venture, private equity and public markets.

Stage	Hybrid fund: about 60% into Southeast VC funds and about 40% direct into startups. Direct checks at seed and early stage with follow-on capacity, e.g. co-investments in a Dec 2024 seed round and a Nov 2025 Series A. Southeast focus (DC to Miami).
Relevant deals	Fintech and enterprise software are stated focus areas. No specific AI-infra, data or quant deal found. Has co-invested in Acre Homes (seed, Dec 2024) and Poppy Flowers (Series A, Nov 2025) per aggregator snippets. Fund II closed at \$20M in April 2024.
Why them	Generalist early-stage Southeast fund whose stated sectors include fintech and enterprise software. Direct seed/Series A checks are small and limited to the Southeast. SimReal's Duke-based COO may give it a Triangle tie, but no AI-infra deals were found.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Front Porch, which backs Southeast fintech and enterprise software and released its first Founder Pulse Survey in September; we build RL environments and verifiers for LLM post-training, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch form: www.frontporchvp.com/contact (asks for stage and pitch deck) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/greggbordes

16 Howard Lerman

Medium fit

Angel investor · **Angel investor**

Duke: Bachelor's, History '02 | Confidence: High | Miami Beach, FL

Angel investor, mostly at pre-seed and seed, and founder and CEO of Roam, a virtual HQ for distributed teams that he funded with \$12M of his own money. He co-founded Yext in 2006 and was its CEO. In September 2025 he joined Orchard Robotics' \$22M Series A.

Stage	Pre-seed and seed mostly; checks \$100K-\$5M
Relevant deals	Orchard Robotics (AI farm-data and robotics; angel in the \$22M Series A led by Quiet Capital and Shine Capital, Sep 2025); no named AI-infra or fintech deal found
Why them	Large-check pre-seed/seed operator-angel with AI in scope and a September 2025 deal; no named AI-infrastructure or fintech deal found.
Hook	<i>You backed Orchard Robotics' \$22M Series A in AI farm data and robotics; we build RL environments, verifiers and expert data for LLM post-training, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published)

17 Joe Mancini

Medium fit

Co-founder & General Partner · **Front Porch Venture Partners**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '12 | Confidence: High

Joe Mancini is Co-founder and General Partner of Front Porch Venture Partners, a Research Triangle hybrid fund that backs Southeast venture funds and invests directly in early-stage startups; Fund 3 opened in January 2026. He previously worked at PRTM (now PwC), on Google's Access and Energy team and at Digital Turbine.

Stage	Hybrid fund. About 60% goes into Southeast venture funds and about 40% directly into early-stage Southeast startups. Fund II closed at \$20M (2024) and Fund 3 opened in January 2026.
Relevant deals	none found (no specific AI, data or fintech direct deals surfaced; the firm has backed 30+ funds and 40 companies in the region since 2020)
Why them	Generalist early-stage tech investor with a strong Duke/Fuqua tie and a Google/software background, but the fund is Southeast-focused, about 60% fund-of-funds, and has no verified AI-infra or fintech direct deals. Contact him rather than Shah, since he is the tech-side partner.
Hook	<i>Your firm's September 2026 Founder Pulse Survey asked Southeast founders about AI and the capital environment; we build RL environments for LLM post-training and are raising our seed now.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch/contact form: www.frontporchvp.com/contact

18 Katelyn Donnelly

Medium fit

Founder & Managing Partner · **Avalanche VC**

Duke: BA Economics & Political Science '08 | Confidence: High | Austin, Texas (LinkedIn and search snippet)

Katelyn Donnelly is Founder and Managing Partner of Avalanche VC, a solo-GP pre-seed and seed fund investing in how people learn, earn and own. She previously founded and led Pearson's \$65M Affordable Learning Fund and began her career at McKinsey. She is a Kauffman Fellow.

Stage	Pre-seed and seed. Third-party profiles report check sizes of \$25K-\$1M. She runs Avalanche as a solo GP.
Relevant deals	No specific deals are verified. Tracxn (search snippet) reports 46 portfolio companies and 1 new investment in the 12 months to March 2026. The names from the discovery stage (Banza, Franzy, Akave, Humanly, Cybernut) are still unconfirmed and should not be cited.
Why them	She is a solo-GP pre-seed and seed investor. Her fund lists AI, future of work and enterprise among its sectors, and its 'earn and own' thesis touches fintech. She has strong Duke ties (Trinity '08). Caveats: her recent pace is slow (Tracxn shows 1 new investment in the 12 months to March 2026), and she is a generalist rather than an AI-infrastructure or quant specialist.
Hook	<i>You built Avalanche around how people learn, earn and own; we turn quant expertise into LLM training signal that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: hello@avalanche.vc or the inquiry form at www.avalanche.vc/contact LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/katelyndonnelly Site: katelyndonnelly.com

19 Marc Andrusko

Medium fit

Partner · **Oak HC/FT**

Duke: Undergraduate degree, magna cum laude | Confidence: High

Marc Andrusko has been a Partner at Oak HC/FT since March 2026, focused on early and growth stage fintech. At Andreessen Horowitz he invested in B2B AI and fintech, including Rillet and Sphere, with capital markets among his thesis areas. Earlier he led Plaid's personal financial management vertical and was a Goldman Sachs VP.

Stage	Early and growth stage fintech at Oak HC/FT. At a16z he invested in B2B AI applications and fintech.
Relevant deals	At a16z: Rillet (AI-native ERP for finance teams) and Sphere (AI-native international tax compliance). Rounds and years were not verified in this batch. His thesis areas included capital markets and AI in accounting. No Oak HC/FT deals verified yet.
Why them	He is an investing Partner focused on fintech and B2B AI, with a stated capital-markets thesis and a background in Goldman rates sales and trading, which suits the Xitadel trading environment. One caveat: Oak HC/FT invests at early and growth stages, so a seed check may be less typical than Series A.
Hook	<i>You worked in interest rate sales and trading at Goldman and list capital markets as a thesis area; we built Xitadel, an RL environment that lifted an open model's trading 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@oakhcft.com (Oak HC/FT general inbox, www.oakhcft.com/contact) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/marc-andrusko-4680ab25 X: x.com/mandrusko1

20 Rob Go

Medium fit

Co-founder & Partner · **NextView Ventures**

Duke: BS Economics '01 | Confidence: High | Boston, MA (NextView is based in Boston/NYC per search snippet)

Rob Go is co-founder and Partner of NextView Ventures, a Boston and New York seed fund backing founders who redesign the 'Everyday Economy.' He invests in marketplaces, vertical SaaS, fintech, AI and digital health. Before NextView he was at Spark Capital, where he helped run Start@Spark.

Stage	Seed (NextView is a seed-stage fund in Boston and NYC)
Relevant deals	Firm-level: NextView invested in Fuse Finance (fintech) in a Series A-II on March 16, 2026, according to a CB Insights snippet. No personal AI-infrastructure, data or quant deal was verified.
Why them	A generalist seed investor whose focus list includes fintech and AI. His thesis centers on end-user and vertical software rather than AI infrastructure or RL tooling, so SimReal's B2B lab-supplier model is only a partial match.
Hook	<i>You co-founded NextView, which backs seed-stage fintech and AI and invested in Fuse Finance in March 2026; we built Xitadel, which lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: rob@nextviewventures.com (published at nextview.vc/team/rob-go and nextview.vc/blog/our-thesis-on-work-equalizing-opportunity (search snippet; an exact-phrase search for 'rob at nextviewventures dot com' returned these NextView pages first, and a search limited to nextview.vc/robgo.org gave the same address)) Fund route: Warm referral preferred; otherwise the contact/pitch route at nextview.vc/approach LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/robgo X: x.com/robgo Site: robgo.org ; robgo.medium.com

21 Thomas D. Lehrman

Medium fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Teamworthy Ventures**

Duke: BA | Confidence: High

Thomas Lehrman is co-founder and Managing Partner of Teamworthy Ventures, which invests from pre-seed (through its Founder Fellowship) to Series A. He co-founded and was Co-CEO of Gerson Lehrman Group (GLG) after working as an analyst at Tiger Management. He sits on the boards of Ibotta and GLG.

Stage	Pre-seed and seed (via the Teamworthy Founder Fellowship), seed and Series A
Relevant deals	Drug Hunter (drug-discovery knowledge platform): Teamworthy led the seed in Sept 2025. Catena Clearing: Teamworthy joined the \$5M seed in Sept 2025.
Why them	He is a founding/seed-stage Managing Partner, so the stage fits. He co-founded GLG, an expert network, which is close to SimReal's expert-data business. No AI or fintech deals were verified.
Hook	<i>You co-founded GLG, the expert network; we turn domain experts' knowledge into verifiers and expert data for LLM post-training, already supplying Surge AI and AfterQuery.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: investors@teamworthy.com (Teamworthy's pitch and investor-relations inbox)

22 W. Bradford (Brad) Stephens

Medium fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Blockchain Capital**

Duke: BA Economics '98 | Confidence: High

Brad Stephens is Co-founder and Managing Partner of Blockchain Capital, which he started in 2013 with his brother Bart as one of the first venture firms focused only on blockchain. The firm has backed Coinbase, Circle and Tether and in April 2026 was raising \$700M for new early-stage and growth funds.

Stage	Seed through growth. In April 2026 the firm was raising \$700M across its seventh early-stage fund and its second growth fund.
Relevant deals	Coinbase, Circle and Tether (crypto trading and payments infrastructure; rounds and years not verified). No AI or RL-environment investment found.
Why them	Duke credentials and seniority are strong and the early-stage fund is active. However, the mandate is crypto-only and no AI or RL investments were found. The only overlap is trading and capital-markets infrastructure, unless SimReal pitches a crypto-trading environment.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Blockchain Capital, backer of Coinbase, Circle and Tether; we built Xitadel, an RL trading environment that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: contact@blockchaincapital.com (official inbox for pitch decks)

23 Will Bumpus

Medium fit

Partner · **Westbound Equity Partners**

Duke: BA Psychology and Asian & Middle Eastern Studies '09 | Confidence: High | Los Angeles, CA

Will Bumpus is a Partner at Westbound Equity Partners, a Los Angeles early-stage fund formerly called Concrete Rose that backs underrepresented founders; it closed a \$100M Fund II in 2024. He was previously Chief of Staff at Headspace, ran business operations at Activision in China and began as an M&A analyst at Perella Weinberg.

Stage	Early stage (pre-seed and seed). Westbound closed a \$100M Fund II in March 2024.
Relevant deals	Firm level (Tracxn): 2025 seed investments in Manas AI and Laborup. A Ooln pre-seed in 2025 is linked to Bumpus personally, but only one indirect snippet supports it. No trading or quant deals found.
Why them	Early-stage generalist fund with a diversity thesis. It has backed AI companies, but no AI infrastructure or trading deals were found. His Perella Weinberg finance background gives a small link to Xitadel.
Hook	<i>You started as an M&A and restructuring analyst at Perella Weinberg; we build finance RL environments for LLM post-training, and our Xitadel environment lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch form with deck upload: westboundequity.com/contact-us

24 Blake Byers

Medium fit

Founder · **Byers Capital**

Duke: BS Biomedical Engineering, Pratt · BS Economics | Confidence: Medium | San Francisco, CA

Blake Byers is founder of Byers Capital, a San Francisco family office he started in 2021 to invest early-stage in tech and biotech. Before that he spent a decade as a partner at GV, where he made early investments in Robinhood and Gusto. He also co-founded NewLimit with Brian Armstrong.

Stage	Early stage, mainly Series A and B, investing family-office capital (aggregators). He participated in a Series A in March 2026. Seed appetite is unverified, though his GV-era first checks into Robinhood and Gusto were very early.
Relevant deals	Robinhood (fintech/trading; reported first investor while at GV) and Gusto (per investor-profile snippets). Personal and Byers Capital portfolio per aggregators: Neuralink, Axiomatic, NewLimit, Benchling, Getlabs, Oryon Cell Therapies. No AI-infra or data deals verified.
Why them	An active personal investor with a tech-plus-bio mandate. Aggregators list AI and enterprise software, but his verified portfolio is bio-heavy (Neuralink, NewLimit, Grail, Denali). He prefers Series A and B, and one aggregator suggests no Byers Capital deals in 2025, so seed appetite is uncertain.
Hook	<i>You backed Robinhood early as a GV partner; we build RL trading environments and verifiers for LLM post-training, and ours lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Firm site www.byerscap.com ; no pitch inbox or form published X: x.com/byersblake Site: www.byerscap.com

25 David Cummings

Medium fit

Founder & CEO · **Atlanta Ventures**

Duke: BS Economics | Confidence: Medium | Atlanta, GA

David Cummings is founder and CEO of Atlanta Ventures, a venture studio and early-stage fund backing Atlanta and Southeast founders from idea to Series A. He co-founded Pardot, sold to ExactTarget for \$95.5M in 2012, founded Atlanta Tech Village and invested early in SalesLoft and Calendly.

Stage	Idea / pre-seed to Series A (Atlanta Ventures is a venture studio and early-stage fund). He is also a prolific personal angel.
Relevant deals	Personal: lead investor in Calendly and investor in SalesLoft (B2B SaaS). Dogwood Ventures, where he is a founding investor, co-led a \$5M seed round in BoodleBox (AI collaboration for higher education) in December 2025, but his decision role at Dogwood is not verified. No AI-infrastructure, data or quant deal was found.
Why them	A hands-on B2B SaaS operator-angel and early-stage fund that lists AI as a focus. However, Atlanta Ventures concentrates on Atlanta/Southeast founders, which weakens the fund route for SimReal. A personal angel check is the more realistic ask.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Pardot and were lead investor in Calendly; we already sell RL environments and expert data for LLM post-training to Surge AI and AfterQuery.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Atlanta Ventures site www.atlantaventures.com (founder office hours and programs) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/davidcummings Site: davidcummings.org

26 Deb Liu

Medium fit

Co-founder & angel investor · **Ember AI**

Duke: BSE Civil Engineering, Pratt '98 | Confidence: Medium | Silicon Valley (Duke Pratt news, search snippet)

Deb Liu is co-founder of Ember AI, an enterprise back-office AI startup, and a Duke Capital Partners Investor Member who writes angel checks at seed and Series A. She created Facebook Marketplace, held product roles at eBay and PayPal, and was CEO of Ancestry from 2021 to January 2025.

Stage Angel checks at seed and Series A: Keebler Health seed (Feb 2025), Sweatpals seed (Oct 2025), Sundial Series A (Jul 2025) and District seed (May 2026, per Tracxn). She is also a Duke Capital Partners Investor Member.

Relevant deals Keebler Health (AI risk adjustment for value-based care), \$6M seed, Feb 2025. Sweatpals (fitness social), \$12M seed, Oct 2025, led by Patron, a16z speedrun and HartBeat Ventures. Only aggregator data supports two more: a Sundial \$23M Series A (Jul 2025) and a District \$15M seed (May 2026). None are AI-infrastructure or trading deals.

Why them She is a Duke engineer (BSE '98) and a payments/marketplace operator who now co-founds an AI startup, Ember AI. She still writes personal angel checks at seed and Series A, including Keebler Health (an AI health startup, seed, Feb 2025), Sweatpals (seed, Oct 2025) and, per Tracxn, District (seed, May 2026). She also has a Duke Capital Partners tie. Caveats: she has no AI-infrastructure or trading deals, and she is a full-time founder.

Hook *You've said not doing AI is like refusing to use Excel, and now you're building Ember AI for back-office automation; we build the RL environments and verifiers that post-train models for expert work.*

Contact Email: debliublog@gmail.com (published at debliu.com/contact and debliu.substack.com/about (search snippet; search limited to debliu.com and debliu.substack.com))
Fund route: Via Duke Capital Partners, where she is an Investor Member: dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu
LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/deborahliu
Site: debliu.com

27 Jason Fernandez

Medium fit

General Partner · **Creci Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '08 | Confidence: Medium | Austin, TX

Jason Fernandez is General Partner of Creci Ventures, an Austin seed-to-Series A fund focused on proptech and marketplaces, and Managing Partner and COO of Quake Capital Partners, a pre-seed and seed accelerator fund. He previously spent 20 years in financial services, including at BASE Equity Partners. He serves on the Fuqua Alumni Council.

Stage	Quake Capital is a pre-seed/seed accelerator fund (Austin, LA, NYC). Creci Ventures writes seed to Series A checks of \$250K-\$2M, typically once a company shows about \$10K+ MRR.
Relevant deals	Creci portfolio includes Nada, LeaseUp and Plotr (proptech / financial software / B2B). No AI-infra, data or quant deal found.
Why them	Active pre-seed/seed and Series A check writer at two vehicles with a Fuqua alumni-volunteer tie. Creci's proptech focus and Quake's accelerator format are a partial mismatch for an AI/RL data company. No 2026-dated source confirms his current roles.
Hook	<i>You spent 20 years in financial services before backing B2B and financial software at Creci; we build RL environments that train LLMs to trade, and already sell to Surge AI and AfterQuery.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Creci site www.creciventures.com ; Quake site www.quakecapital.com (no pitch inbox or form seen) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/jason-r-fernandez

28 Jeremy Levine

Medium fit

Partner · **Bessemer Venture Partners**

Duke: BS Computer Science & Economics '95 | Confidence: Medium | New York, NY

Jeremy Levine is a Partner at Bessemer Venture Partners in New York, where he has invested in software and internet companies since 2001. Early-stage companies he backed include LinkedIn, Pinterest, Shopify, Yelp and MindBody, all of which went public. Before Bessemer he was a McKinsey consultant.

Stage	Seed through growth at firm level. On 23 Sept 2026 BVP announced a \$5.75B close: \$1.75B for seed and early stage, \$4B for growth. Levine's own stage mix in 2026 is unverified, and one third-party article calls him one of the firm's most visible growth-stage voices.
Relevant deals	Bessemer led or co-led Series A rounds in Unframe (enterprise AI, \$30M) and Sett (agentic AI for gaming); only a third-party aggregator credits Levine personally. Wonderful is a Bessemer AI deal with no confirmed Levine role. His historical early bets are LinkedIn, Pinterest, Shopify, Yelp and MindBody.
Why them	Partner at a multi-stage firm that just closed a \$1.75B seed and early-stage fund (Sept 2026). Signal lists AI and fintech among his focus areas. His personal seed and Series A activity in 2026 is unverified, and one third-party source frames him as growth-oriented.
Hook	<i>You said, as Bessemer closed \$1.75B for seed and early-stage companies, that the firm aims to back founders 'before the market fully recognizes the opportunity'; we build RL environments and verifiers for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Bessemer contact page: www.bvp.com/contact LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/jeremyl
Note	Fund already in SimReal pipeline: bessemer (contact: Janelle Teng Wade)

29 Kent Ho

Medium fit

Founder & General Partner · **S28 Capital**

Duke: BA Economics | Confidence: Medium | San Francisco / Silicon Valley (S28 Capital HQ per search snippet)

Kent Ho is Founder and General Partner of S28 Capital, a San Francisco fund founded in 2015 that invests at seed and Series A in enterprise SaaS and enterprise infrastructure. He co-founded Harbor Pacific Capital in 2009, investing early in Palantir, Coupang, JD.com and Zoom, after working in Goldman Sachs Private Wealth Management.

Stage	Seed and Series A. One profile counts 17 seed deals (average round about \$3.9M) and 13 Series A deals; \$170M under management. S28 calls itself a multistage tech fund.
Relevant deals	Late-2025 co-investments (Sep-Nov 2025) in Relixir, Cactus, Andel, Arcjet, Keycard, Flai and Shuttle. The search snippet named S28 as co-investor but gave no round details, and the snippet did not describe what these companies do. Historical: Palantir, Zoom, Coupang, JD.com (via Harbor Pacific).
Why them	A seed and Series A GP whose fund focuses on enterprise SaaS and enterprise infrastructure, which matches SimReal's B2B AI-training infrastructure. His Goldman background suits a quant founding team. One caveat: an aggregator snippet showed no S28 deals yet in 2026; the latest deals seen are from Sep-Nov 2025.
Hook	<i>You back enterprise infrastructure at seed and Series A through S28, after early bets on Palantir and Zoom; we build RL environments and verifiers that AI labs use for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: community@S28Capital.com (inbox on s28capital.com; may be a general community address)

30 Lawson DeVries

Medium fit

Managing General Partner · **Grotech Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua | Confidence: Medium

Lawson DeVries is Managing General Partner of Grotech Ventures, an early-stage firm founded in 1984 that backs seed and Series A technology companies outside Silicon Valley. He joined Grotech in 2005 after equity research at Deutsche Bank and became Managing GP in 2020.

Stage	Seed and Series A; initial checks of \$500K-\$5M
Relevant deals	Sturdy.ai (AI customer-intelligence platform built on unstructured customer data): Grotech joined its \$6M seed in April 2025, which Voyager Capital led. CrowdStreet (online real-estate investment platform): Grotech joined a \$43M financing (year not stated). Yardstik: 2026 investment (round not stated).
Why them	Senior decision maker at a seed/Series A B2B software fund that lists AI and fintech as focus areas and joined an AI-data seed round in 2025. The fund is a generalist rather than AI-infrastructure specialist and has an outside-Silicon-Valley mandate. His Duke graduation year is not stated.
Hook	<i>Grotech joined Sturdy.ai's \$6M seed in April 2025, backing AI built on unstructured customer data; we build the expert data, verifiers and RL environments that post-train LLMs for specialist work.</i>
Contact	Email: ldevries@grotech.com (published at www.grotech.com/team/lawson-devries and www.grotech.com/team (search snippet; two separate searches limited to grotech.com both returned this address)) Fund route: info@grotech.com (Grotech's general inbox)

31 Mengxi Lu

Medium fit

Angel investor · **Angel investor**

Duke: Master of Engineering Management '12 | Confidence: Medium | San Francisco Bay Area (Kanmon is in San Mateo, CA)

Mengxi Lu is co-founder and CEO of Kanmon, which lets vertical software and marketplace companies offer financing to business customers, and an angel writing \$5K-\$50K checks mostly into early-stage fintech, data infrastructure and AI. He previously worked at Mission Lane/LendUp and Tumblr, and his angel portfolio includes Moov and Salsa.

Stage	Angel, about 80% early stage; typical check \$5K-\$50K, sweet spot \$25K
Relevant deals	Moov (fintech/embedded banking; \$5.5M seed round led by Bain Capital Ventures, Aug 2020, where he was one of 27 angels; one aggregator calls it Series A); Sandbar (seed, Jan 2023, \$5M round); Salsa (embedded payroll; \$10M round, May 2023, labeled Series A by one aggregator and Seed by another; his latest recorded deal); TrueAccord; Novo. 'Stability' appears in his portfolio list, but no source confirmed it is Stability AI, so it should not be described as an AI deal.
Why them	His angel thesis explicitly covers fintech, data infrastructure and AI at early stage, and he is a fintech-infrastructure founder, so a trading RL environment and data business matches his stated interests. Check sizes are small (\$5K-\$50K), and his latest recorded deal is from 2023.
Hook	<i>You angel-invested in fintech infrastructure like Moov and Salsa, with a thesis spanning data infrastructure and AI; we built Xitadel, a trading RL environment where fintech meets AI infrastructure.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: No published inbox; personal site mengxi.lu or Wellfound wellfound.com/p/mengxi LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/mengxilu X: twitter.com/mengxi Site: mengxi.lu

32 Robert Ravanshenas

Medium fit

Investment Partner · **Maven Ventures**

Duke: BS Economics '15 | Confidence: Medium | Los Angeles, California

Robert Ravanshenas is an Investment Partner at seed-stage consumer-tech firm Maven Ventures, focusing on AI, fintech and longevity. He joined Maven in 2015 as its first Associate, moved to finance and operations at a portfolio company, then returned. He invested in Validity, founded by Duke FinTech master's students.

Stage	Seed. Maven is a seed-stage firm with about \$200M AUM across five funds, including a \$60M Fund IV.
Relevant deals	He works closely with Daybreak Health, Trainwell, Validity, House Numbers and Ottopia (rounds and years not stated). No AI-infrastructure or trading deals verified.
Why them	His Duke ties are strong (Duke Econ '15, investor in the Duke FinTech M.Eng startup Validity, and he reportedly lectures in the Duke FinTech master's), and his AI/fintech focus is relevant. However, Maven's published mandate is consumer software at seed, and his AI/fintech interest is framed as emerging consumer trends. SimReal's B2B RL-environment and data business is a mandate mismatch, so pitch him for a personal or Duke-network intro rather than as a Maven lead.
Hook	<i>You focus on AI and fintech at Maven and backed Validity, founded by FinTech master's students; we built Xitadel, a trading RL environment that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: hello@mavenventures.com (Maven's Get in Touch inbox; send business, vision, team, traction and deck; mutual intro preferred) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/robbrav

33 Scott Raney

Medium fit

Managing Director · **Redpoint Ventures**

Duke: BS Electrical Engineering, Pratt '91 | Confidence: Medium

Scott Raney is a Managing Director at Redpoint Ventures, which he joined in 2000, investing in enterprise software with a focus on cloud infrastructure, open source and SaaS. He is one of Redpoint's leads on its 2026 Series A in physical-AI company Mind Robotics, and was named a Duke trustee in July 2026.

Stage	Redpoint bio: seed, early and growth stages, focused on cloud infrastructure, open source and SaaS. A third-party search summary gives his title as 'Managing Director, growth'. He is listed as one of Redpoint's leads on Mind Robotics' 2026 Series A. Seed appetite is plausible but unproven.
Relevant deals	Mind Robotics (physical AI, 2026 Series A; Raney is listed as one of Redpoint's leads). Older names (Stripe, HashiCorp, Heroku, LaunchDarkly) appear only in a me.sh aggregator snippet and are unverified.
Why them	Long-time investor in infrastructure, open-source and developer software who is still leading AI-related deals in 2026, and a Duke trustee since July 2026. He may now sit on Redpoint's growth side, so his appetite for a seed-stage check is uncertain.
Hook	<i>You're one of Redpoint's leads on Mind Robotics' 2026 Series A and have long backed cloud infrastructure and open-source software; we build the RL environments and verifiers labs use for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Warm intro; Redpoint profile www.redpoint.com/our-people/scott-raney (no pitch inbox verified) X: x.com/sraney Site: medium.com/@sraney
Note	Fund already in SimReal pipeline: redpoint (contact: Jordan Segall)

34 Sergey Khusnetdinov

Medium fit

Founder & Managing Partner · **Ga^3in Ventures**

Duke: MBA · 2013 | Confidence: Medium | Unclear. He teaches at SKEMA's North Carolina campus (Jan 2025 post). Searches gave the firm's HQ as Seattle (unconfirmed).

Sergey Khusnetdinov is Founder and Managing Partner of Ga^3in Ventures, a New York firm investing in AI, robotics and frontier tech from pre-seed to late private rounds. He spent fifteen years at SAP and Microsoft before working as an operator and founder. He co-presides over DukeGEN and teaches entrepreneurship at SKEMA Business School.

Stage	Multi-stage per the current site ('Frontier Tech & Pre-IPO Venture Capital'; 'from first checks into category defining companies to their final private rounds'), with selective pre-seed and seed investments through the Ga^3in Early program. Superscout lists pre-seed, seed and early Series A. Sectors: AI, robotics, frontier tech, critical infrastructure. He invests his own capital alongside investors in every vehicle the firm offers. Fund and check sizes not verified. Based in New York, not Seattle.
Relevant deals	none found (no named AI, data or fintech deals surfaced; the firm reports 60+ supported startups, mostly Web3, and partnerships with Polygon Labs, Aptos and SES)
Why them	The firm's stated thesis is pre-seed to early Series A AI and frontier tech, with Web3/crypto (capital-markets adjacent) roots. It is also built around a Duke-alumni investor network, which suits SimReal's Duke-linked founding team. Caveats: no specific AI-infrastructure or trading deals were verified, and the vehicle looks small (accelerator/syndicate style).
Hook	<i>Your Ga^3in Early program makes selective pre-seed and seed investments in AI, robotics and frontier tech; we're a seed-stage team building RL environments and verifiers for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Ga^3in Early program via the official site gain.ventures LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/today/author/husnetdinov Site: Fuqua alumni Q&A: www.fuqua.duke.edu/alumni/connect/alumni-q-a/sergey-khusnetdinov

35 Shaan Puri

Medium fit

Founder & GP · **Shaan's All Access Fund**

Duke: BS Biology '10 | Confidence: Medium

Founder and GP of Shaan's All Access Fund, a rolling fund targeting pre-seed and seed, and co-host of My First Million. He was acting CEO of Bebo, acquired by Twitch in 2019, and co-founded the crypto newsletter Milk Road. As an angel he backed Gumloop's 2025 Series A.

Stage	Fund targets pre-seed and seed (average check ~\$150K per aggregator); his named 2025-26 angel checks are in Series A rounds
Relevant deals	Gumloop (AI workflow automation): angel in the \$17M Series A led by Nexus, Jan 2025. Viktor (AI): Series A (~\$75M), May 2026, per Tracxn. Health: Hone Health, Superpower. No 2025-26 seed-stage deal named; no trading or quant deals.
Why them	Active Duke-alum angel and rolling-fund GP with 2025 AI-tooling exposure (Gumloop). Overall a generalist with a heavy consumer and health tilt, with no trading or ML-infrastructure focus.
Hook	<i>You backed Gumloop's \$17M Series A in AI workflow automation; we build RL environments and verifiers that post-train the models behind such tools for expert work, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published)

36 William Crowder

Medium fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Aperture Venture Capital**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '99 | Confidence: Medium

William Crowder is Co-founder and Managing Partner of Aperture Venture Capital, a seed fund founded in 2021 that invests in fintech and enterprise software and prioritizes Black, Latin and female founders. He launched Comcast Ventures' \$20M Catalyst Fund in 2012 and has taught venture capital at Fuqua since 2024.

Stage	Seed is the core stage. Third-party profiles (Signal NFX, vcbeast) list pre-seed, seed, Series A and later.
Relevant deals	No AI or data deals found at Aperture. Earlier, the Comcast Ventures Catalyst Fund he launched in 2012 backed fintechs Flutterwave and Paystack (Paystack was acquired by Stripe); round stages not stated.
Why them	Seed-stage decision maker whose thesis is capital-markets and financial infrastructure, which matches the Xitadel trading angle. But SimReal is AI training infrastructure rather than a fintech product, and the fund prioritizes Black, Latin and female founders. He teaches at Fuqua, a direct Duke tie for Amaris.
Hook	<i>You launched Comcast Ventures' Catalyst Fund, which backed Flutterwave and Paystack; we build RL environments for finance, and our Xitadel trading environment lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Contact page aperturevc.com/contact (no pitch inbox listed); team page aperturevc.com/personnel/william-crowder

37 Amit Mehra

Medium fit

General Partner · **Borderless Capital**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua | Confidence: Low | Miami, FL (single search snippet, unverified)

Amit Mehra is a General Partner at Borderless Capital, where he manages investments in Web3 and decentralized-infrastructure startups; the firm also invests in climate tech and AI. He was previously Founding Principal at Unicorn India Ventures and earlier worked at Deloitte. He is a CFA charterholder.

Stage	Seed through Series B per Signal. Borderless invests early-stage in Web3, decentralized infrastructure/DePIN, climate tech and AI.
Relevant deals	Borderless Capital, at firm level, invested in NeuraMint, a Web3-native AI-agent and tokenization platform (\$5M seed, Jan 2026). Aggregators count about 6 AI and 9 DePIN deals. He is also a personal angel in Web3 startups and an LP in Shima Capital, Blockchain Founders Fund and Woodstock. No deal attributed to him personally was verified.
Why them	An investing partner at a seed-to-Series B fund with fintech and AI-crypto deals, and a former FX/finance background suits a trading environment. The fund's core is Web3/DePIN/climate, not AI post-training. The Duke MBA year is inferred, not stated, and there is no 2026-dated confirmation of his role.
Hook	<i>You manage Web3 investments at Borderless, which joined NeuraMint's \$5M AI-agent seed in January 2026; we built Xitadel, a trading environment that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Team page www.borderlesscapital.io/team (no stated pitch inbox) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/aamehra X: x.com/amitm_eth

38 Ashley Flucas

Medium fit

Founder & General Partner · **Flucas Ventures**

Duke: BA Political Science '08 | Confidence: Low | West Palm Beach, FL (per search snippet)

Ashley Flucas is founder and solo GP of Flucas Ventures, an AngelList syndicate that invests pre-seed to Series A, and has invested in 250+ startups since 2018, including Databricks, Brex, Mercury and Qonto. She was previously a capital-markets attorney at Davis Polk in London and is now COO and General Counsel of Summit Ventures.

Stage	Pre-seed to Series A via an AngelList syndicate of roughly 2,000-3,500 LPs. She has made 250-275+ investments, and the syndicate has deployed \$75M-\$100M+ since 2020.
Relevant deals	Personal or syndicated: Databricks (data/AI infrastructure), Brex, Mercury, Qonto, Pipe, Bolt (fintech), AngelList, Turing. A 2025 investment in Limitless (acquired by Meta, Dec 2025) is aggregator-reported. Rounds and years for the core deals were not verified.
Why them	A syndicate lead with a strong fintech and data-infrastructure portfolio (Databricks, Brex, Mercury) and AI listed as a focus. Her syndicate is generalist, and no specific 2026 seed deal in AI infrastructure or quant was verified. She is still worth a try because the syndicate reaches thousands of LPs.
Hook	<i>You backed data and fintech infrastructure like Databricks, Brex and Mercury; we build RL environments and expert data for LLM post-training, starting with Xitadel, our trading environment.</i>
Contact	Email: ashley@flucasvc.com (published at Search snippet from a search limited to interview pages: probably alltheangels.substack.com/p/-angel-interview-10-ashley-flucas or medium.com/the-syndicate-investor/syndicate-lead-profile-1-ashley-fluc (the Q&A profiles where she gives her contact details). The exact page was not pinned down.) Fund route: Flucas Ventures syndicate page venture.angellist.com/ashley-flucas/syndicate LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/asflucas Site: flucasvc.com (named in the same snippet)

39 Jason Freedman

Medium fit

General Partner · **Peak State Ventures**

Duke: BA Public Policy & Economics '02 | Confidence: Low

Jason Freedman is a General Partner at Peak State Ventures, which invests from seed to Series B in future of work, proptech, fintech and related areas. He previously ran four startups with three exits, including FlightCaster, a machine-learning company from an early Y Combinator batch, and 42Floors, sold to Knotel in 2018.

Stage	Seed, Series A and Series B; typical checks \$100K-\$5M. Recent deals include a pre-seed (Buildroid, Nov 2025) and seeds (Swell, Feb 2025; Hamming AI, Dec 2024)
Relevant deals	Hamming AI (AI voice-agent testing platform), \$3.8M seed in Dec 2024; Peak State is on the investor list and Mischief led the round. A profile snippet also lists Ironclad, Snapdocs, Doppler and Fieldwire among companies he has backed (stage and year not stated). Buildroid \$2M pre-seed, Nov 2025 (sector not verified).
Why them	Writes seed checks and backed Hamming AI's seed round. Hamming tests and evaluates AI agents, the same layer as SimReal's verifiers and RL environments, and the fund lists FinTech among its focus areas. Caveats: the firm's core thesis is future of work and proptech, and no 2026-dated activity was found.
Hook	<i>Peak State joined Hamming AI's \$3.8M seed for AI voice-agent testing; we work in the same evaluation layer, building verifiers and RL environments for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@peakstate.vc (Peak State's general inbox); team page peakstate.vc/team/jason-freedman

40 Pamir Gelenbe

Medium fit

Founder & Managing Partner · **Libertus Capital**

Duke: BSc Electrical Engineering | Confidence: Low

Pamir Gelenbe is Founder and Managing Partner of Libertus Capital, a London-based firm he founded in 2017 that invests in decentralised systems, enterprise blockchain and digital assets. He was previously a Partner at Hummingbird Ventures, worked at Morgan Stanley and D.E. Shaw, and has invested in Kraken, Ledger and Crypto Facilities.

Stage	Early stage, seed to Series B per an aggregator snippet; also token sales. Focus is crypto/Web3 protocols and companies.
Relevant deals	Personal or fund investor in Kraken, Ledger, Crypto Facilities and ShapeShift. The Libertus portfolio includes TON (private token sale, March 2025), Mintbase, Oasis, GitPOAP, Revv and Bonfire.
Why them	He has a quant-trading background (D.E. Shaw, Morgan Stanley) and backed trading venues (Kraken, Crypto Facilities), which suits the Xitadel pitch. However, Libertus is a crypto/Web3 fund, and no investment after March 2025 was found, so its appetite for an AI-data seed deal in 2026 is uncertain.
Hook	<i>You worked at Morgan Stanley and D.E. Shaw before backing Kraken and Crypto Facilities; we built Xitadel, a trading RL environment that lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: No fund pitch inbox found; personal profile about.me/pamirgelenbe Site: about.me/pamirgelenbe

41 Padowithz "Pad" Alce

Medium fit

Angel investor · **Angel investor, Duke Capital Partners**

Duke: LLM Law & Entrepreneurship, Duke Law '11 | Confidence: Medium | Charlotte, NC

Pad Alce is founding partner of AI Patent Law, a Charlotte-based AI and machine-learning patent boutique whose clients, from pre-seed startups to unicorns, have raised over \$2B. He invests through Duke Capital Partners, lectures at Duke, and leads IP strategy at ForgeUp Ventures, an AI/ML venture studio.

Stage	Angel and early stage. He invests via Duke Capital Partners, Duke's early-stage network for Duke-affiliated startups. ForgeUp Ventures (founded 2025) is a venture studio that gives early-stage AI/ML startups \$150K+ of services for equity.
Relevant deals	none found (no named angel deals surfaced; his AI exposure is through AI Patent Law clients and the ForgeUp AI/ML venture studio)
Why them	His work is entirely focused on AI startups, through patent strategy for about 60 AI-native companies and the ForgeUp AI/ML venture studio, and he invests at angel stage via Duke Capital Partners. However, I found no named angel deals in AI infrastructure, data or fintech, and his checks are likely small or syndicated.
Hook	<i>You founded AI Patent Law, which serves about 60 AI-native startups; we build proprietary RL environments and verifiers, such as our Xitadel trading environment, for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Info@aiPatentLaw.com (his law firm's general inbox, not a fund) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/padowithzalce Site: www.aipatentlaw.com

42 Lisa Burton O'Toole

Medium fit

Executive Director · **HearstLab**

Duke: BSE Mechanical Engineering, Pratt '07 | Confidence: Low

Lisa Burton O'Toole invests at HearstLab, Hearst's early-stage arm backing women-led startups in media, data, technology and finance, which she joined as a vice president in 2017 before becoming Executive Director. She previously launched and sold marketing-technology startup AdMass and holds an MS and PhD in mechanical engineering from MIT.

Stage	Seed, pre-Series A and Series A, women-led startups only. Typical first check is about \$500K in pre-Series A rounds, with up to \$1M available. HearstLab has made 56-70+ investments, mainly in women-led B2B/B2B2C SaaS.
Relevant deals	none found (no specific AI/data deals attributed to her in search results)
Why them	HearstLab invests at seed and Series A in data and technology B2B startups, which fits SimReal's stage and data business. However, it backs only women-led companies, so SimReal qualifies only if a woman is a lead founder. No AI or quant deals were found for her, and she is not a classic GP, so decision-making authority is unclear.
Hook	<i>You took AdMass through HearstLab's program before joining to invest in women-led data and technology startups; we're a seed-stage data company supplying RL environments and expert data to Surge AI and AfterQuery.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published)

43 Adam Besvinick

Low fit

Founder & Managing Partner · **Looking Glass Capital**

Duke: BA Public Policy Studies '09 | Confidence: High | New York, NY

Founder and Managing Partner of Looking Glass Capital, a New York pre-seed and seed fund that aims to be the 'first yes' for mission-driven founders in health, climate and empowerment. Looking Glass co-led Simuhealth's \$2.62M pre-seed in December 2025. He was previously an investor at Anchorage Capital and Deep Fork Capital.

Stage	Pre-seed and seed; leads or co-leads; initial checks \$300K-\$400K
Relevant deals	Co-led (with Parade Ventures) Simuhealth's \$2.62M pre-seed (Dec 8 2025); Trially AI (seed, Sep 2025); Titan Intake (seed, May 2025); Kaavio (pre-seed, May 2026). No fintech or trading deals found.
Why them	Active pre-seed lead with 2025-2026 deals, but the thesis is health, climate and empowerment, not AI infrastructure or fintech.
Hook	<i>You founded Looking Glass to be founders' first yes and co-led Simuhealth's \$2.62M pre-seed; we're quants building RL environments and verifiers for LLM post-training, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Fund site: lookingglass.vc LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/besvinick X: x.com/Besvinick Site: lookingglass.vc

44 Ali Behbahani

Low fit

Partner & Co-Head of Healthcare · **NEA**

Duke: Bachelor's degrees in Biomedical Engineering, Electrical Engineering & Chemistry | Confidence: High

Ali Behbahani is a Partner and co-head of healthcare at NEA, which he joined in 2007, focusing on biopharmaceuticals and medical devices. His board roles include CRISPR Therapeutics, Black Diamond Therapeutics and Korro Bio. He holds an MD and an MBA, and earlier did research at the NIH and Duke.

Stage	NEA invests from seed through growth; his healthcare practice backs early-stage biopharma and medtech companies. A first investment in Tectura Therapeutics is recorded in 2026; the round type was not found.
Relevant deals	None found in AI, data, infrastructure or fintech. His healthcare boards include CRISPR Therapeutics, Black Diamond Therapeutics and Korro Bio, and Tectura Therapeutics was a 2026 investment.
Why them	He is purely a healthcare and biotech investor with no AI, data or fintech deals. He is useful mainly as a Duke-alumni route to NEA's technology partners.
Hook	<i>You co-head NEA's healthcare practice, with boards including CRISPR Therapeutics; we build RL environments for LLM post-training, outside your sector, so we'd value an intro to NEA's tech partners.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: No founder pitch inbox found; ask him for an intro to NEA's technology partners

45 Dan Levitan

Low fit

Co-founder & General Partner · **Maveron**

Duke: BA '79 | Confidence: High | Seattle, WA (Maveron; Startup Grind Seattle event per discovery snippet)

Dan Levitan is Co-founder and General Partner of Maveron, the consumer-focused venture firm he started with Howard Schultz, which invests at seed and Series A in consumer companies. Maveron's 2026 investments include Wonderdog and Kin Health.

Stage	Early-stage (seed / Series A) consumer companies
Relevant deals	none found (2026 Maveron deals are consumer, e.g. Wonderdog and Kin Health)
Why them	Maveron invests only in consumer businesses, so B2B AI/RL infrastructure falls outside its thesis. He is at most a senior Duke-network connector, not a likely seed lead for SimReal.
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Firm site www.maveron.com (no published pitch inbox) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/dlevitan X: x.com/Levitan Site: maveronvc.substack.com (Maveron's Substack, search snippet)

46 Doug Brown

Low fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Dental Innovation Alliance**

Duke: BS '78 · MBA, Fuqua '84 | Confidence: High

Doug Brown is Co-founder and Managing Partner of Dental Innovation Alliance, which funds early-stage dental-technology companies through its VC Fund I. He spent about 30 years in dentistry, including as CEO of a North Carolina-based 20-practice group that later merged into larger DSOs. DIA's portfolio includes dental-AI companies Relu and DentalBee.

Stage	Early stage. DIA connects and funds early-stage dental-technology companies through Dental Innovation Alliance VC Fund I, LP.
Relevant deals	Relu, an AI platform that automates design and administrative work for dental cases. DIA invested in its seed round and took part in its Series A on Aug 4, 2026, its latest first-time investment. DentalBee, AI-powered dental documentation (DIA VC Fund I; round and year not stated). Perceptive, dental imaging, AI and robotics (round and year not stated). The rest of the portfolio is dental-only (e.g. Alta Smiles orthodontics, with a 2026 follow-on).
Why them	Active early-stage Managing Partner, but DIA's mandate is dental-only, so SimReal's trading RL environment is outside its thesis. The only overlap is DIA's dental-AI deals; no personal angel investing found.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Dental Innovation Alliance, which backed Relu's seed and Series A for AI that automates dental case work; we build the expert data and verifiers domain-specific AI like that depends on.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: inquiries@dialliance.com or the inquiry form at www.dialliance.com/contact-us LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/doug-brown-7b6b7a32

47 Gonzalo Costa

Low fit

Co-founder & General Partner · **NXTP Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '01 | Confidence: High | Buenos Aires, Argentina

Based in Buenos Aires, Gonzalo Costa co-founded NXTP Ventures in 2011 and is a General Partner of the Latin American B2B fund, which invests from pre-seed to Series A in cloud, fintech and AI. NXTP led AI startup Luzid's \$2.8M pre-seed and was an early Auth0 investor.

Stage	Pre-seed to Series A. Checks of \$0.5M-\$5M from a \$98M B2B fund (cloud, fintech, B2B).
Relevant deals	Led AI startup Luzid's \$2.8M pre-seed with Oceans Ventures and Quiet Capital (year not confirmed). Early investor in Auth0 (developer identity infrastructure), Nuvemshop, Mural, Frete.com and Betterfly. Fintech holdings include Barte.
Why them	Stage and sector fit well (B2B, AI, fintech, pre-seed to A), but NXTP invests only in Latin American startups and SimReal is not one. He is useful mainly as a Duke/Fuqua contact or for co-investor intros.
Hook	<i>Your fund led AI startup Luzid's \$2.8M pre-seed and backed Auth0 early; we're B2B AI infrastructure too, selling RL environments and verifiers to AI data providers.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@nxtp.vc (general inbox, www.nxtp.vc/contact)

48 Jeff Terrell

Low fit

Managing Partner · **Arboretum Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '13 | Confidence: High

Jeff Terrell is Managing Partner at Arboretum Ventures, an early-stage healthcare and medtech venture firm he joined in March 2025. He previously spent 13 years at Hatteras Venture Partners in Durham, co-leading the medical-device practice. His boards include AtaCor Medical, Boomerang Medical and Pharaoh Neuro.

Stage	Early-stage healthcare and medtech venture. Arboretum describes itself as 'Early-Stage Healthcare Venture Capitalists' and has an active Fund VI.
Relevant deals	none found (medtech portfolio: AtaCor Medical, Boomerang Medical, Pharaoh Neuroscience via Fund VI)
Why them	Pure healthcare and medtech early-stage fund, with no AI-infrastructure, data, fintech or trading investments found. The only link to SimReal is the Duke/Durham connection.
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Investment Opportunity Form: www.arboretumvc.com/contact LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/jeff-terrell-a515a24

49 Jim Scheinman

Low fit

Founding Managing Partner · **Maven Ventures**

Duke: BS Neuropsychology, Trinity '88 | Confidence: High | Silicon Valley / San Francisco Bay Area

Jim Scheinman is Founding Managing Partner of Maven Ventures, a Silicon Valley seed fund whose \$60M Fund IV (2024) focuses on consumer software with a heavy emphasis on consumer AI. He was an early investor in Zoom and Cruise and has had six unicorn exits.

Stage	Seed. Fund IV is a \$60M seed fund (2024), bringing AUM to \$200M. Maven's latest deal seen is Ease Health's Series A on March 2, 2026.
Relevant deals	No AI-infrastructure, data, fintech or quant deals found. Known for Zoom (early investor) and Cruise. Recent deals are consumer and health AI, e.g. Ease Health Series A (Mar 2026).
Why them	He is an active seed GP and an AI enthusiast, but Maven invests only in consumer software (consumer AI, health, families, climate). SimReal is B2B AI-training infrastructure, so the sector does not match. Mainly useful as a Duke connector.
Hook	<i>You launched Maven's \$60M Fund IV with a heavy emphasis on consumer AI; we build RL environments and verifiers that improve the models consumer AI products are built on.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: hello@mavenventures.com with a brief business description and deck; Maven prefers a mutual introduction LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/jscheinman X: x.com/jimscheinman Site: jimscheinman.com

50 John Tough

Low fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Energize Capital**

Duke: BS | Confidence: High

John Tough co-founded Energize Capital, a Chicago firm investing in energy-transition software, and serves as its Managing Partner. The firm reports \$1.7B AUM and more than 35 portfolio companies. He sits on the boards of Sitetracker, DroneDeploy, Nozomi Networks, Matroid, PVcase and Aurora Solar.

Stage	Energy-transition and climate software from Series A through growth (Ventures funds plus a growth-equity platform). Typical checks are USD 10-20M. Example: led Nixtla's \$16M Series A in Feb 2026.
Relevant deals	Firm: led Nixtla's \$16M Series A (Feb 2026; time-series foundation model TimeGPT; Energize partner Juan Muldoon took the board seat, not Tough). Personal board seats: Matroid (computer-vision AI) and Nozomi Networks (OT/industrial cybersecurity).
Why them	The fund only invests in climate and energy-transition software, and its \$10-20M checks are a poor match for a seed round. The partial upside: in 2026 it led a Series A in time-series foundation models (Nixtla), and energy trading overlaps with Xitadel's trading environment.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Energize, which led Nixtla's \$16M Series A in February 2026 for time-series foundation models; we built the Xitadel trading environment, which lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Contact form on his blog johntough.com (invites Energize inquiries); team page energizecap.com/team/john-tough Site: johntough.com ('Tough CAPITAL' blog with an Energize Capital page; search snippet)

51 Kathryn Minshew

Low fit

Operating Partner & Angel investor · **XFactor Ventures**

Duke: BA Political Science & French '08 | Confidence: High

Kathryn Minshew is an angel investor and Operating Partner at XFactor Ventures, which aims to be the first check in female-founded companies. She co-founded The Muse and was its CEO from 2011 to 2023, growing it past 70 million annual users. She advises a Fortune 100 company on change management in the age of AI.

Stage	Angel / first check (XFactor Ventures calls itself the 'first check' in female-founded companies)
Relevant deals	Intello (business/productivity software, angel; PitchBook). No AI, data, fintech or quant deals found
Why them	An operator-angel focused on the future of work and HR, with about 88% of checks in female-founded companies. No AI infrastructure, data, fintech or quant investments found. Her stage (first check) matches, but her sector does not. The fit improves only if SimReal has a female co-founder, which was not verified.
Hook	<i>You advise a Fortune 100 company on change management in the age of AI; we build the RL environments, verifiers and expert data that teach LLMs skilled professional work like trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: hello@xfactor.ventures (XFactor inbox when no partner intro; send company, founders, short pitch, location, deck) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/kathryn-minshew Site: www.kminshew.com

52 Kerry Rupp

Low fit

General Partner · **True Wealth Ventures**

Duke: BA Biology '93 | Confidence: High | Austin, Texas

Kerry Rupp has been general partner at Austin-based True Wealth Ventures since 2016; the fund makes seed investments in women-led companies that improve human or environmental health. She was previously CEO of the DreamIt accelerator and held VP roles at AllRecipes and LexisNexis. She also teaches the NSF I-Corps program.

Stage	Seed / early stage; earlier fund plan was \$250K-\$500K checks
Why them	Seed stage fits, but the fund's thesis is women-led companies improving human or environmental health. SimReal's AI/RL trading-environment business sits outside that thesis, and whether SimReal is women-led was not verified.
Hook	<i>You teach the NSF I-Corps program on commercializing university research; we're quants turning that kind of research into RL training environments and verifiers for LLMs.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch form: truewealthvc.com/share-your-big-idea (contact page: truewealthvc.com/contact-us) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/kerryrupp

53 **Lindy Morris Fishburne**

Low fit

Founding Managing Partner · **Breakout Ventures**

Duke: BA Cultural & Physical Anthropology '92 | Confidence: High

Lindy Morris Fishburne is founding managing partner of Breakout Ventures, whose \$114M Fund III (March 2026) backs seed and Series A startups applying AI to biology, chemistry and neuroscience, with \$500K-\$5M checks. She was previously executive director of Breakout Labs, the Thiel Foundation's grant program for early-stage science research.

Stage	Seed and Series A; Fund III (\$114M, March 2026) plans 20+ companies with checks of about \$500K-\$5M
Relevant deals	Fund III (\$114M, closed March 2026) is AI-focused, backing startups 'unlocking the complexity of science with AI'. Earlier deals: Canaery (neurotech, seed, 2022), Surf Bio (seed \$16M), AquaPoro (seed \$5M, June 2026 per an investor-profile snippet). No direct AI-infrastructure, RL or fintech deals found.
Why them	A fresh 2026 AI-focused seed/Series A fund, but its thesis is scientist-founded biology and chemistry platforms rather than AI infrastructure, LLM training data or trading tech. It is a stretch fit unless SimReal pitches verifiers and environments for scientific reasoning.
Hook	<i>You raised Breakout's \$114M Fund III to back startups 'unlocking the complexity of science with AI'; we build the RL environments and verifiers that teach models expert-domain reasoning.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: contact@breakout.vc (general inbox on breakout.vc/contact)

54 **Lisa Blau**

Low fit

Founding Partner · **Able Partners**

Duke: BA '97 | Confidence: High | New York, NY

Lisa Blau is a Founding Partner of Able Partners, the New York early-stage consumer fund she co-founded with Amanda Eilian in 2016, focused on health and wellness. She is an active angel investor in consumer health, especially women-led companies, and earlier co-founded the newsletter Vital Juice, acquired by Tasting Table.

Stage	Early stage (mainly seed), with follow-ons in later rounds. The fund was started in 2016 with the founders' own capital.
Relevant deals	none found in AI infrastructure, data, fintech or quant. Closest is DUOS, an AI benefits platform for seniors (\$130M Series B, Oct 2025, portfolio round). 2025-2026 activity: Bevimi (seed, Nov 2025) and KilgourMD (2026).
Why them	The fund is focused on consumer health and wellness brands, a clear sector mismatch with B2B AI training infrastructure. The Duke tie is the only real angle.
Hook	<i>Your portfolio at Able includes DUOS, an AI benefits platform for seniors; we build the RL environments and verifiers used to train the models behind AI products like it.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@ablepartners.nyc (general inbox on ablepartners.nyc)

55 Namita Thapar

Low fit

Shark Tank India investor · **Angel investor**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '01 | Confidence: High | India

Executive Director of Emcure Pharmaceuticals and a shark on every season of Shark Tank India, backing mostly consumer and health brands. She has backed more than 100 startups, including NeoSapien, an AI-native wearable, in January 2025. Earlier she spent six years at Guidant in the US.

Stage	Early-stage angel (Shark Tank India deals)
Relevant deals	NeoSapien (AI-native wearable; Rs 80 lakh for 4% on Shark Tank India S4, Jan 2025), the closest to AI; other 2025 deals (Crunchbase): Symbionic, The Bear House, COGRAD, Boba Bhai, Tikitoro, Aquapeya, FAE Beauty (Jan-Mar 2025); otherwise consumer and health brands
Why them	A prolific, active angel, but in Indian consumer and health brands; no AI, fintech or quant deals found.
Hook	<i>You backed NeoSapien's AI-native wearable on Shark Tank India; we build RL environments and verifiers that train LLMs for expert work, starting with trading.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published)

56 Paul Straub

Low fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Wireframe Ventures**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '05 | Confidence: High

Paul Straub co-founded Wireframe Ventures, a Mill Valley seed-stage fund backing founders who improve the health of people and planet, and is its Managing Partner. He led investments including Electriphi (acquired by Ford), OpenInvest (acquired by JPMorgan), Span and Salient Predictions.

Stage	Pre-seed to Series A. Wireframe is a seed-led fund that also took part in LevelTen Energy's Series A; about 70% of Fund I companies went on to raise institutional Series A rounds.
Relevant deals	OpenInvest, impact-investing fintech later acquired by JPMorgan (he led; round and year not stated). Salient Predictions (he led). Near Space Labs (he led). Mostly climate otherwise: Electriphi (acquired by Ford), Span, Gridware, LevelTen Energy (Series A), Synop, and recently Bedrock Energy (geothermal).
Why them	Active seed-stage Managing Partner with a confirmed Duke MBA, but Wireframe's thesis is climate, bio and health, so SimReal's trading RL environment is outside it. Leading the OpenInvest fintech deal is the only overlap.
Hook	<i>You led Wireframe's investment in OpenInvest, an impact-investing fintech later acquired by JPMorgan; we built Xitadel, a trading RL environment that lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Founder form www.wireframevc.com/general/contact-us (climate, bio, health focus); info@wireframevc.com for general inquiries LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/paulstraub X: twitter.com/pstraub

57 Sydney Thomas

Low fit

Founder & General Partner · **Symphonic Capital**

Duke: BA Public Policy '10 | Confidence: High | San Diego, CA (Business of San Diego); some profiles list Oakland, CA

Sydney Thomas is Founder and General Partner of Symphonic Capital, a pre-seed fund backing companies that make life better for the 99% in health, wealth and climate resilience; it closed a \$13.5M Fund I in 2025. She previously helped scale Precursor Ventures to 400+ investments and is a Kauffman Fellow.

Stage	Pre-seed and seed, typical checks \$100K-\$250K. \$13.5M debut fund closed in 2025.
Relevant deals	No AI infrastructure, data or quant deals found. A \$6.0M seed in Flourish Care (March 2026) shows she is still investing. Her thesis covers fintech and financial health.
Why them	Right stage (pre-seed) and fintech is in scope, but the thesis is consumer access and equity in health and wealth for underserved households. SimReal sells B2B AI training infrastructure, which is off-thesis.
Hook	<i>You launched Symphonic in 2023 to back companies improving health, wealth and climate resilience for the 99%; we improve open models' financial reasoning with Xitadel, a building block for AI wealth tools.</i>
Contact	Email: sydney@sympmonic.vc (published at mercury.com/blog/fundraising-today-august-2023-sydney-thomas (search snippet; page not opened)) Fund route: hi@sympmonic.vc (pitches and inquiries; www.symphoniccapi.com/how-we-work) Site: www.symphoniccapi.com/newsletter (fund newsletter)

58 Todd Pietri

Low fit

Co-founder & Co-Managing Partner · **Activate Venture Partners**

Duke: BA English | Confidence: High

Todd Pietri is Co-founder and Co-Managing Partner of Activate Venture Partners, which invests at seed and Series A in digital health and applied technology from New York and Bethlehem, PA. He co-founded predecessor Milestone Venture Partners in 1999 and has taken part in 50+ equity financings.

Stage	Seed and Series A; checks of \$100K-\$5.0M (sweet spot \$1.5M)
Relevant deals	Activate seed deals: ChorusRx (Feb 2026), Triplemoon (\$3.5M seed for tech-enabled pediatric mental-health care, Oct 2025), Ride Health (Dec 2025). No AI-infrastructure or fintech deals found.
Why them	He is a decision maker at an active seed and Series A fund (deals in Oct 2025, Dec 2025 and Feb 2026). However, Activate's recent deals are all digital health, so an RL-environment and expert-data company is outside its core thesis.
Hook	<i>You've guided more than a dozen portfolio companies to exits, including software and data businesses; we build the RL environments, verifiers and expert data that post-train LLMs.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@activatevp.com (Activate's general inbox); site activatevp.com

59 Carmichael Roberts

Low fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Material Impact**

Duke: BS Organic Chemistry '90 · PhD Organic Chemistry '95 | Confidence: Medium | Boston, MA

Carmichael Roberts co-founded and is Managing Partner of Boston-based Material Impact, which backs materials, energy and robotics startups and raised a \$352M third fund in 2023. He also co-leads the investment committee of Bill Gates's Breakthrough Energy Ventures. A chemist turned entrepreneur, he holds an MIT Sloan MBA.

Stage	Early-stage company building at Material Impact (materials, energy, robotics; \$352M Fund III in 2023, about \$800M AUM). Breakthrough Energy Ventures invests across stages in climate tech.
Relevant deals	none found (portfolio is climate, materials, energy and robotics)
Why them	An active early-stage decision maker, but his mandate is climate, materials and hard tech, a sector mismatch for SimReal's LLM post-training and trading environments. The only partial overlap is robotics at Material Impact.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Material Impact to back materials, energy and robotics startups; we build RL environments and verifiers, the training infrastructure that AI and robotics models depend on.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@materialimpact.com (Material Impact's general inbox)

60 David Lamond

Low fit

Managing Partner · **Lamond Ventures**

Duke: BA History, Trinity '97 · JD, Duke Law '06 | Confidence: Medium

David Lamond is Managing Partner of Lamond Ventures, investing personal and family capital at angel and seed stage, mostly in biotech, therapeutics and medtech. He was previously CEO and CIO of Lamond Capital Partners. He has held board seats at Quince Therapeutics, Inquis Medical and Cyllene Therapeutics and sits on the Pratt Board of Visitors.

Stage	Angel/seed with personal and family capital (e.g. Dopple seed round, Mar 2021). Lamond Ventures' most recent recorded investment was Cyllene Therapeutics on 7 July 2026.
Relevant deals	Disclosed deals are Cyllene Therapeutics (Jul 2026), Inquis Medical, MindRhythm, Dopple (seed, Mar 2021) and an early YouTube stake. He also holds a board seat at a company named Windfall; whether it is the wealth-data company Windfall Data was not verified, so confirm before treating it as a data investment. No confirmed AI or fintech deals. Lamond Capital Partners (2011-2016) was a public-market 13F filer.
Why them	He is an active Duke-alumnus angel with his own capital, but his disclosed portfolio is biotech, therapeutics and medtech, with no AI, data or fintech deals found. The only AI link is the family's 2026 Duke gift for advanced computing and AI-driven hardware, and his seat on the Pratt Board of Visitors.
Hook	<i>You joined your family's \$30M early-2026 gift for advanced computing and AI-driven hardware; we work one layer up, building RL environments and verifiers for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/david-lamond-b7338915b

61 John Glushik

Low fit

Managing Director · **HG Ventures**

Duke: BS Mechanical Engineering & Materials Science, Pratt '90 | Confidence: Medium

John Glushik has been a Managing Director of HG Ventures, The Heritage Group's corporate venture arm, since its 2018 launch, investing in advanced materials, sustainability, infrastructure and industrial tech. He was previously a venture partner at Intersouth Partners and the founding director of the Duke Angel Network.

Stage	Corporate VC investing from seed to Series A and later (e.g. Renewal Mill \$2.5M seed; Duality Robotics \$12M Series A). The thesis is advanced materials, sustainable tech, industrial/B2B, energy and infrastructure.
Relevant deals	Firm-level: Duality Robotics/Duality AI \$12M Series A (Dec 2021), with Drive Capital, AngelPad and 99 Tartans as co-investors; ML-training simulation environments. R3 Robotics (AI-powered battery recycling, Feb 2026). Renewal Mill \$2.5M seed. It was not confirmed which HG MD led each deal.
Why them	His corporate VC mandate is industrial, materials and climate, so the AI/quant fit is weak. Duality Robotics (simulation environments for ML training) is the one adjacent deal. As founding MD of the Duke Angel Network he is a valuable connector to Duke angels.
Hook	<i>Your team at HG Ventures backed Duality Robotics' \$12M Series A for ML-training simulation environments; we build the equivalent for LLMs: RL environments and verifiers for post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Warm intro preferred; HG asks founders to connect on LinkedIn and reviews cold outreach with clear sector fit: hgventures.com/approach LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/johnglushik

62 Josh Felser

Low fit

Co-founder & Managing Partner · **Climactic**

Duke: BA Political Science & Economics '86 · MBA, Fuqua '90 | Confidence: Medium

Josh Felser is Co-founder and Managing Partner of Climactic, a seed climate-tech fund that raised \$65M for its first fund and backs software-first companies in energy, AI, automation and robotics. He also co-founded Freestyle Capital, an early-stage fund that backed Airtable, Intercom, Patreon and BetterUp.

Stage	Seed and early stage. Climactic raised a \$65M first fund and writes checks of about \$1.5-3M into software-first climate companies in energy, AI, automation and robotics.
Relevant deals	Freestyle Capital (which he co-founded in 2008; early-stage, \$385M AUM, 130+ tech companies) backed Airtable, Intercom, Patreon and BetterUp. No AI-infrastructure, data, trading or fintech deals at Climactic were verified.
Why them	He is a senior Duke alum (BA and Fuqua MBA) and a seed-stage fund founder, but Climactic's mandate is climate. SimReal's trading RL environments and expert data fall outside it. The pitch works only as a Duke-network or personal-angel note.
Hook	<i>You co-founded Climactic to back seed-stage, software-first companies in energy, AI, automation and robotics; we build the RL environments and verifiers that train AI models for expert work.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: info@climactic.vc (Climactic's general inbox); team page www.climactic.vc/team/josh-felser LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/joshfelser Site: Climactic Podcast: www.climactic.vc/podcasts/climactic-podcast

63 Lia Cromwell

Low fit

Partner · **UpWest**

Duke: BA Public Policy, Economics & Spanish '15 | Confidence: Medium | Tel Aviv, Israel

Lia Cromwell is a Partner at UpWest in Tel Aviv, where she leads the Israel investment team and writes pre-seed and seed checks for Israeli founders. She joined in 2017 as the fund's first permanent Israel team member, after roles at CreditSights and FiscalNote, and made Forbes 30 Under 30.

Stage	Pre-seed and seed checks, only for Israeli founders, with companies in Israel and the US
Relevant deals	CyCognito (cybersecurity), Balance (fintech/B2B payments) and Canopy, plus stealth companies (rounds and years not stated). UpWest led pre-seed and seed rounds in AI and fintech.
Why them	Her stage and sectors fit (pre-seed and seed, AI, fintech), but UpWest backs only Israeli founders. SimReal's founders (Cambridge, LSE, Duke) are not known to be Israeli, so this is a mandate mismatch unless a founder qualifies.
Hook	<i>You pointed to vertical AI's latent potential in CTech's 2026 VC Survey; we build it for trading; our Xitadel environment lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: lia@upwest.vc (published at medium.com/upwest-labs/upwest-office-hours-your-us-go-to-market-cant-w (search snippet; medium.com is blocked, so the page was not opened)) Fund route: UpWest contact page: upwest.vc/connect LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/liacromwell Site: medium.com/@lmcromwell

64 Lori Cashman

Low fit

Founder & General Partner · **Visible Ventures**

Duke: BA '94 | Confidence: Medium

Lori Cashman is Founder and General Partner of Visible Ventures, an early-stage firm founded in 2016 as Victress Capital and renamed in 2023, investing at seed and Series A across health, wealth and opportunity. In September 2026 Visible acquired dcdx, a Gen Z research and strategy firm.

Stage	Seed and Series A, early stage
Relevant deals	none found. No specific AI, data or fintech deal was verified. Tracxn snippet: 34 portfolio companies, 3 new investments in the 12 months to Sept 2025, none so far in 2026.
Why them	The thesis is generational and consumer-leaning (health, wealth, mobility) with a diverse-founder mandate. Fintech and AI are listed only as secondary sectors, and new investing looks slow (no 2026 deals logged). Fit improves if SimReal has a female co-founder. Duke ties are very strong.
Hook	<i>You acquired Gen Z research firm dcdx to build 'a new kind of human intelligence company'; we turn human expertise into expert data and verifiers for LLM post-training.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Pitch form: visibleventures.com/pitch LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/lori-cashman X: x.com/visiblevc_

65 Luis von Ahn

Low fit

Angel investor · **Angel investor**

Duke: BS Mathematics '00 | Confidence: Medium

Co-founder and CEO of Duolingo and an angel investor in e-learning, music and mobility apps. He founded reCAPTCHA, which Google bought in 2009, and co-developed CAPTCHA with Manuel Blum at Carnegie Mellon. In February 2026 he invested in Desquare, a Swedish digital-signage software firm.

Stage Angel

Relevant deals none found in AI/data/fintech; Desquare AB (Designage digital-signage CMS, Sweden; invested Feb 2026 through a Swedish consortium led by Martin Norstrom, terms undisclosed), Gridwise, Trala

Why them Active angel in 2026, but his small portfolio is in edtech and music, not AI infrastructure or fintech.

Hook *You co-developed CAPTCHA at Carnegie Mellon and sold reCAPTCHA to Google; we build the verifiers and expert data that teach LLMs expert work, starting with trading.*

Contact Email: not found (not published)

66 Nikin Shah

Low fit

Co-founder & General Partner · **Front Porch Venture Partners**

Duke: MBA, Fuqua '12 | Confidence: Medium

Nikin Shah is Co-founder and General Partner of Front Porch Venture Partners, a North Carolina hybrid fund that backs Southeast venture funds and invests directly in early-stage startups. He leads the firm's healthcare-focused investments, drawing on experience in growth strategy and commercialization. Fund 3 opened in January 2026.

Stage Hybrid fund. About 60% goes into Southeast venture funds and about 40% directly into early-stage Southeast startups. Fund 3 opened in January 2026.

Why them Healthcare-focused partner at a Southeast fund-of-funds and direct investor, so his sectors do not match AI training data or trading tech. Same firm as Mancini, so contact Mancini instead.

Contact Email: not found (not published)
Fund route: Pitch/contact form: www.frontporchvp.com/contact

67 Salman Azhar

Low fit

General Partner · **Azimuth Opportunity Fund**

Duke: MS Computer Science '90 · PhD Computer Science '94 | Confidence: Medium | Durham, NC (Wellfound snippet)

Salman Azhar is General Partner of Azimuth Opportunity Fund, which buys pre-IPO unicorn shares from early investors, and Executive in Residence at Duke Fuqua. He co-founded more than 30 predictive-computing, business-intelligence and analytics startups and has invested in more than 200 startups over 25 years.

Stage	The fund buys pre-IPO unicorn shares from early investors, usually at a 40-50% discount (late stage). Investor-profile snippets also describe him as an angel who focuses on seed rounds and has invested in 200+ startups over 25 years, but no dated 2025-2026 seed deals were found
Relevant deals	No specific AI or data seed deals verified. An SPV named Azimuth Opportunity Kueski, LLC filed a Form D in 2025 (secondary vehicle). As an operator he co-founded DecisionStreet, Swans International, SoftWeb and 30+ predictive-computing and analytics startups
Why them	His AI, NLP and financial-systems background fits SimReal's product very well, and he is a long-time angel in the Duke ecosystem. His fund, however, does late-stage pre-IPO secondaries, so a seed pitch has to target his personal angel checks, and no dated 2025-2026 seed deals were found.
Hook	<i>You co-founded more than 30 predictive-computing and data-analytics startups; we build the RL environments and verifiers that lifted an open model's trading performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: salman.azhar@duke.edu (published at www.fuqua.duke.edu/faculty/salman-azhar and scholars.duke.edu/person/azhar (search snippet, duke.edu-restricted search)) Fund route: Wellfound wellfound.com/p/sazhar or Fuqua faculty page www.fuqua.duke.edu/faculty/salman-azhar ; no Azimuth pitch inbox LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/salmanazhar X: x.com/sazhar

68 Squire Servance

Low fit

Founder & Managing Partner · **Syridex Bio**

Duke: JD, Duke Law '08 · MBA, Fuqua '08 | Confidence: Medium | Princeton, New Jersey

Squire Servance is Founder & Managing Partner of Syridex Bio, a Princeton life-sciences impact investment and venture-creation firm backing therapies for diseases that disproportionately affect underserved populations. A patent and life-sciences attorney, he was previously SVP, General Counsel & Corporate Secretary at Repligen. He is a Rutgers University trustee.

Stage	Seed and Series A in biotech, therapeutics and healthcare. Syridex Bio was founded in 2022 and describes itself as a venture-creation and investment firm. It received an NJEDA allocation of up to \$5M for early-stage NJ life-science companies and was reported to be raising a \$150M fund.
Relevant deals	Antigenix Therapeutics (preclinical antibody-drug-conjugate oncology) and Qunova (AI-driven population-health platform). No round or year was found, and no 2025 or 2026 deals were found.
Why them	The fund invests only in life sciences and healthcare, a sector mismatch for SimReal's AI and trading infrastructure. His 2026 congressional campaign may also limit his time for investing.
Hook	<i>You backed Qunova, an AI-driven population-health platform, through Syridex Bio; we build the RL environments, verifiers and expert data used to post-train LLMs.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Firm site www.syridexbio.com/about-us ; no pitch inbox published Site: www.squireservance.com

69 Camille Samuels

Low fit

Partner · **Venrock**

Duke: Bachelor's, Biology '93 | Confidence: Low

Camille Samuels is a partner at Venrock, the venture firm that began as the Rockefeller family's venture arm. She invests in early-stage biotech, medical devices and consumer health, preferring to back or help create seed-stage companies. Her boards include Cavalry, Iris, Mahzi and Unity.

Stage	Early-stage biotech, medical devices and consumer health. Her Signal profile says she prefers seed-stage companies and helping to create them, with a stated check range of \$2M-\$40M.
Why them	She is a healthcare and biotech investor with no AI-infrastructure, data or fintech deals found, so she is a sector mismatch for SimReal. Venrock's tech partners would fit better than she does.
Contact	Email: not found (not published) Fund route: Contact page www.venrock.com/contact ; business plans go to the relevant investment team (technology or healthcare).

70 Jared Weinstein

Low fit

Founder · **Overton**

Duke: BA Public Policy '02 | Confidence: Low | Birmingham, Alabama

Jared Weinstein runs Overton, his Birmingham, Alabama investing vehicle, backing local founders, making concentrated bets on high-conviction entrepreneurs and seeding emerging managers. He was a founding partner of Thrive Capital (GP 2011-2022) and earlier served as President George W. Bush's personal aide. He sits on the boards of Justworks and LeafLink.

Stage	Through Overton he invests in local Birmingham founders, makes 'concentrated bets in high conviction entrepreneurs' and seeds emerging investment managers (as an LP). Round stage is not stated, but it looks like angel or early-stage.
Relevant deals	None found since leaving Thrive; Overton's deals are not public. At Thrive he was a founding partner while the firm backed 39 unicorns. Current director at Justworks and LeafLink.
Why them	He decides alone, with Thrive and early-Palantir pedigree. But since 2022 his investing has been described as Birmingham founders and LP commitments to emerging managers, with no AI or fintech deals and no clear seed check pattern seen. Stage and sector fit are weak.
Hook	<i>You've made concentrated bets on high-conviction entrepreneurs through Overton since leaving Thrive; we're quant founders whose RL trading environment lifted an open model's performance 12% on unseen market data.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/jared-weinstein-3b22b538

71 Melinda French Gates

Low fit

Founder · **Pivotal Ventures**

Duke: BS Computer Science & Economics '86 · MBA, Fuqua '87 | Confidence: Low

Melinda French Gates is founder of Pivotal Ventures, which invests mainly as an LP in women-led funds and increasingly directly in startups serving women and families. Pivotal made a \$3M direct investment in Binti, an AI-driven child-welfare software company, in 2026. In June 2026 she committed another \$215M to Pivotal for women's health.

Stage	Mainly an LP in women-led and early-stage VC funds (e.g. Magnify Ventures Fund II, 2026), plus a growing book of direct startup investments (Tia, Summer Health, Binti). The stages of the direct deals were not confirmed.
Relevant deals	Binti: \$3M direct investment, 2026 (AI-driven software for child welfare). LP in Magnify Ventures Fund II, July 2026 (care economy, including AI for the home). No AI-infrastructure, data, fintech or quant investments found.
Why them	Pivotal invests for social impact (women, families, caregiving, women's health), and mostly as a fund LP. A CNBC 2025 piece points to a separate investor running the investments day to day. SimReal's RL trading environments fall outside that mandate, and she is very unlikely to answer a cold email.
Hook	<i>You backed Binti's AI-driven child-welfare software with a \$3M direct investment from Pivotal; we build the RL environments and expert data that make models reliable in specialised domains.</i>
Contact	Email: not found (not published) LinkedIn: www.linkedin.com/in/melindagates Site: www.pivotalventures.org/founder (official founder bio, search snippet)

Worth a manual check · 3

Name	Firm	Why
Nikhil Mittal	BlueRidge Ventures	Pre-seed AI fund (\$3M) that sources from Duke alumni and states conviction in fintech infrastructure. Strong fit. Left out only because his Fuqua MBA year is not public; check it in the Duke/Fuqua alumni directory. www.openvc.app/u/nikhilmittal
Kurt Schmidt	Duke Capital Partners	Managing Director of Duke's own early-stage fund (formerly Duke Angel Network), which only backs Duke-affiliated teams. He attended Duke Law but the degree year is not public. Best institutional route either way. dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/team/kurt-schmidt
Elle Leemay Chen	Reciprocal Ventures	Duke BA; fintech/crypto fund. Left out because her class year and whether she leads deals as a Venture Partner are not public. signal.nfx.com/investors/elle-leemay-chen

Checked and left out · 58

Name	Firm	Reason
Aaron Patzer	Founder & CEO, Vital	Duke degree confirmed and he has an angel profile, but no 2025-26 angel or seed deal was found; the latest dated deal in the snippets is Shen.AI (pre-seed, Oct 2020). A 'Fjord Ventures' managing-partner label in aggregators looks like a mix-up with a life-sciences firm.
Adam Carson	JPMorgan Chase	fact-check: Fails criterion 2. He stepped down as Point72 Ventures Partner in January 2025, was an advisor until February 2026, and since January 2026 has headed Chase Digital Assets at JPMorgan Chase, which is an operating role. He is no longer a VC decision maker. This is the 'moved to an operating role' case.
Adelina Dasso	Accion Impact Management	Fails criterion 3: she invests growth equity in established financial institutions through the Accion Digital Transformation Fund, not at angel, pre-seed, seed or Series A. No evidence she invests through Accion Venture Lab or as an angel.
Ali Byrd	Resonance Companies	Fails criterion 2. He left Towerview Ventures in 2020 (LinkedIn snippet: Founding MP 2018-2020) and in 2026 is an operating executive (Chief Value Officer, Resonance Companies), with no evidence he leads investments or angel-invests now.
Ashley Brasier	Angel investor	No verified angel deal in 2025-2026; latest named deal is boam.ai seed (Dec 2022). Signal lists her as an active angel (\$10K-\$100K), so recheck if a recent deal turns up.
Ashwin Ramachandran	Dragonfly	His Duke degree was completed in 2019, after the 2018 cutoff. Duke Computer Science's '2019 Graduation: Degrees Conferred' page lists him among the BS/BA recipients with Computer Science as first major at the May 12, 2019 commencement.
Barry Myers	Pappas Capital	Fails criterion 2: he is a Senior Venture Partner, and the only portfolio roles found are board-observer seats (Aer Therapeutics, Tune Therapeutics; earlier Gentis, TYRX). Nothing shows him leading investments. Pappas Capital invests only in life sciences, so SimReal is outside its mandate. No personal angel investing was found. His Duke degrees (MD/PhD 1991, MBA 2004) do meet criterion 1.
Ben Hamner	Sumble	Angel deals found (Marimo, Predibase, Coiled), but none dated 2025-2026; he is now running his own startup, Sumble (Series A mid-2025).
Bill Quintenz	No QED Investors affiliation found. The Duke bio matches Brian Quintenz	Identity and role not supported: nothing links a 'Bill Quintenz' to QED Investors, and QED's 2026 partner list does not include him. The matching Duke credentials belong to Brian Quintenz, a former regulator and policy executive who now serves on boards (SUI Group, Kalshi). He is not a key decision maker at a seed or Series A fund.
Blake Goodner		Duke T'96, but a hedge-fund manager (public markets), no early-stage vehicle

Brad Lightcap	Undisclosed new venture	No personal 2025-2026 angel/seed checks found: one personal angel deal (Klarity Series A, Jan 2022); the OpenAI Startup Fund he managed is corporate capital. Left OpenAI in Aug 2026 to 'start something new' (details undisclosed). Worth re-checking if the new venture is a fund.
Cari Coats	Accendo Leadership Advisory Group	Not shown to be a 2026 investment decision maker. She is co-founder and managing partner of Accendo Leadership Advisory Group (an advisory firm, not a fund) and a board director of the venVelo and FireSpring early-stage funds. No source shows her leading or approving investments or angel investing herself; venVelo's managing director is listed as Jonathan Molayem. No 2025-2026 activity was found.
Chris Ryan	Moelis Asset Management	Fails criterion 3. Archean Capital Partners is a GP-seeding vehicle that anchors first-time private-equity firms, and Moelis Asset Management does private credit and PE. No evidence was found of angel, pre-seed, seed or Series A startup investing; Signal's fintech pre-seed tag is unsupported by any deal.
Chulmin Lee		Fuqua MBA 2001, but VIG Partners (Korea) is private equity
David Thacker	Google DeepMind	Fails criterion 2. He left the Greylock GP role and is listed as VP Product at Google DeepMind (since 2024 per a search summary), with Greylock showing him only as a Venture Partner. There is no evidence he leads investments or angel invests in 2026.
Doug Higgins	359 Capital	fact-check: No evidence he makes investment decisions: TechCrunch names Michael Spirito as 359 Capital's managing partner and Higgins as 'board partner and co-founder'; the fund's recent deals are Series A and later.
Dylan Smith	Box	Duke economics graduate and Box co-founder/CFO; angel record is thin (4 companies) with the latest deal in Jan 2023, so no 2025-2026 activity.
Elle Leemay Chen	Reciprocal Ventures	Two criteria cannot be supported: (1) the Duke graduation year is unknown, so a degree completed in 2018 or earlier is unconfirmed; (2) her title is Venture Partner with no evidence that she leads investments, and her 2026 status is unverified. The search budget ran out before these could be checked.
Eric Savage	Unitus Capital	Fails criteria 2 and 3: his role is investment banking and advisory at Unitus Capital, with no evidence that he personally makes seed or Series A equity investment decisions in 2026. India impact focus; sector mismatch.
Fred Ehrsam	Paradigm	fact-check: No longer an active investing decision maker: Paradigm's team page lists him as 'Co-Founder & Senior Advisor' and he is Co-Founder & CEO of Nudge (neurotech).
Gautam Bazaz	Amarnath Partners	No named angel or seed deals found for 2025-26. Current public role is mainly health-sector convening (Global Health Forum CEO).
Grant Newlin		Fuqua MBA student in 2021, so graduated after 2018
Henry Yin		Duke Law alumnus, corporate lawyer at Loeb & Loeb, not an investor
Jason Robins	Co-founder & CEO, DraftKings	Duke Econ/CS graduate and an angel with 27 investments, but the latest dated deal found is Kidsy (seed, Mar 2024); no 2025-26 deal was verified.
Joanna Rees	West Global	Criteria 2 and 3 not supported: in 2026 she is Executive Chairman of a brand and strategy firm, with no evidence of an active early-stage fund or of personal seed or Series A investments in 2025-2026. Consumer focus is a sector mismatch.
Joe Wu	MFund	Criterion 2 cannot be supported: Crunchbase lists MFund as closed, and no 2025-2026 investments, fund news or current role were found for Magic Capital. His focus is also Chinese internet companies. His Duke degree (Fuqua MBA '04) does qualify.
Juan Pablo Cappello		Duke AB 1989, venture lawyer (Private Advising Group), not an investor
Justin Klein		Duke '99, MD '04, but Vensana Capital is medtech venture-growth equity (commercial stage), not angel/seed
Kerstin Dittmar		Duke '06, but L2 Point Management does late-stage structured investments
Kip Frey	HG Ventures	fact-check: No longer a decision maker: his LinkedIn title is now 'Senior Advisor, New Ventures, at The Heritage Group'; John Glushik took over as Managing Director of HG Ventures in 2023.

Kurt Schmidt	Duke Capital Partners	Criterion 1 cannot be supported. The official bio confirms he attended Duke Law, but no source found gives the degree type or the year he completed it, so 'Duke degree completed 2018 or earlier' is unverified. Every other criterion holds and he is a strong institutional route: DCP's mandate fits SimReal through its Duke COO. Recommend a manual check of his Duke Law degree and year (e.g. his LinkedIn), then include as a priority contact if it is confirmed.
Lyndsay Lyle	Skyline Capital	No verified angel or seed checks in 2025-26. Skyline Capital is a family office (Ketchum, ID). The only seed deals found (Traini, May 2024; XRUN, June 2022, PitchBook snippet) may belong to a different 'Skyline Capital'.
Matt McIlwain	Madrona Venture Group	No Duke degree. Madrona's official team profile lists his education as Dartmouth College (undergraduate), a Harvard Business School MBA and a master's in public policy from Harvard Kennedy School, with no Duke degree. The Duke claim in the discovery record came from a podcast-description snippet and looks wrong.
Meranee Phing Naaman		Duke '98, but The Riverside Company is private equity / buyout
Michelle Egger		Duke MBA '20 (after 2018); XFactor Ventures investment partner
Mitch Mumma	Intersouth Partners	Fails criterion 3 (and, for new deals, criterion 2): Intersouth Partners says it is not making new investments, with about zero new investments a year over the past decade. No evidence was found that Mumma angel-invests personally at seed or Series A in 2025-2026.
Natalie Hwang	Apeira Capital	Stage criterion not supported. In 2026 coverage, Apeira is described as investing in late-stage to pre-IPO private technology companies, pairing long positions with tactical shorting of private valuations. The 'Series A through C' description comes from an older PR-agency page, and no seed or angel activity was found. Her Duke BA year is also not stated, though it is certainly before 2018.
Nikhil Mittal	BlueRidge Ventures	The year of his Duke Fuqua MBA could not be found, and sources only say he 'attended' Fuqua, so a degree completed in 2018 or earlier is not confirmed. Also, his LinkedIn headline still shows EY, so BlueRidge may be a side role. He is a strong-fit lead worth a manual check of the Fuqua year.
Phillip Graham	Pappas Capital	Fuqua MBA year not found, so the 2018 cutoff cannot be confirmed. He is a Principal with only board-observer roles and no evidence of leading investments. Pappas Capital invests only in life sciences.
Ravi Gupta	Sequoia Capital	fact-check: Criterion 3 fails: he does not invest at angel, pre-seed, seed or Series A. He joined Sequoia in January 2020 as a partner on the growth team (TechCrunch 2019-08-28 'Instacart CFO Ravi Gupta to exit for Sequoia Capital' and Instacart bio, search snippets). NFX Signal lists his check range as \$10M-\$200M with a \$25M sweet spot, and his known deals (Faire, Remote, Meter, Ramp, Fireblocks, Sierra) are growth-stage (https://signal.nfx.com/investors/ravi-gupta , search snippet). Since December 2025 his main job has been Co-Founder and Co-CEO of Ithaca Holdco, a \$1B+ vehicle to acquire and modernize an existing company, which is buyout-style rather than early-stage investing (Yahoo Finance and Bloomberg 2026-03-10, search snippets). No seed or Series A deal led by him was found.
Ravi Trivedi	Srijan Capital	Fuqua MBA and angel/seed investor (Srijan Capital), but no dated 2025-26 deal was found; India/Singapore-based with a SaaS and consumer-internet focus.
Ruby Grewal	Duke Capital Partners	Her active angel investing in 2025-2026 cannot be verified (the DCP spotlight is undated). Her current role is a biopharma operating job (CSO, Immunovant, per LinkedIn snippet), and her stated angel focus is biotech, a sector mismatch.
Scott Weiner	SW Consulting	He has left Pappas Capital, and after a stint at Amzak Health he now runs SW Consulting, a life-science advisory firm. That means he is no longer a fund decision maker (fails criterion 2), and he invested only in life sciences.
Shaurya Aggarwal	Lightspeed Venture Partners	Fails criterion 3: his role is in Lightspeed's Growth practice and no angel, seed or Series A activity was found. His Duke graduation year is also unconfirmed. Useful at most as a Duke warm route to Lightspeed's seed team.

Shep Moyle	Angel investor	Long-time angel and Duke Capital Partners investor, but no named deals found and Duke degree type/year not stated in snippets.
Sima Sistani		Duke T'01, operator (Houseparty, WeightWatchers); no fund or documented angel activity found
Tarun Thakur	Veza	Self-described 'Angel Investor and Advisor' since 2020, but no named deals were found; criterion 2 is unverified.
Ted Wang	ICONIQ Growth	No evidence that he holds an early-stage decision-making role in 2026. Snippets say he left Cowboy Ventures and is now a Partner at ICONIQ Growth, which is growth-only. He also moved into executive coaching (Stoked Advisors, announced around 2022). His Duke class year is not stated
Tim Schulte		Duke BA; Council Capital is healthcare PE/growth and his role is portfolio operations, not deal lead
Todd Creech		Fuqua alumnus, but HealthQuest Capital is healthcare growth equity
Uriridiakoghene "Ulili" Onovakpuri	Motley Fool Ventures	Her 2026 role is Venture Partner at Motley Fool Ventures (since July 2025). I found no evidence that she leads or decides investments there, so criterion 2 is not supported. Also a sector mismatch: her stated focus is digital health, medical devices, HR tech and future of work, and MFV mostly does Series A for companies with \$1M+ ARR. She left Kapor Capital, where she was Managing Partner, in May 2025.
Yi Shi	Lilly Asia Ventures	Criterion 3 could not be confirmed: no source seen in this pass shows LAV investing at seed or Series A, and no 2026 role confirmation was found. LAV is also a biomedical-only fund, so SimReal is outside its mandate (sector mismatch).
Zack Scott	Norwest Venture Partners	Criterion 2 is unverified: his 2026 status at Norwest was not confirmed (latest role evidence is the 2022 hiring release). He is also a healthcare-only GP, a clear sector mismatch with SimReal. His Duke credentials (BA 1995, Fuqua MBA 2005) do look valid.
garheng kong		HealthQuest Capital is healthcare growth equity, not early stage
lawrence lenihan		left FirstMark; runs Resonance (fashion brand platform), not investing
neil roth		orthopedic surgeon, DCP member-angel only
samson mesele		USV Partner & General Counsel (legal role, not investing)
trevor kiviati		Duke Law '16 investor-member at an alternative asset manager; not a fund decision maker